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Recursion

Blake Crouch

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First Edition

BARRY

November 2, 2018

Barry Sutton pulls over into the fire lane at the main entrance of the Poe Building, an Art Deco tower glowing white in the illumination of its exterior sconces. He climbs out of his Crown Vic, rushes across the sidewalk, and pushes through the revolving door into the lobby.

The night watchman is standing by the bank of elevators, holding one open as Barry hurries toward him, his shoes echoing off the marble.

“What floor?” Barry asks as he steps into the elevator car.

“Forty-one. When you get up there, take a right and go all the way down the hall.”

“More cops will be here in a minute. Tell them I said to hang back until I give a signal.”

The elevator races upward, belying the age of the building around it, and Barry’s ears pop after a few seconds. When the doors finally part, he moves past a sign for a law firm. There’s a light on here and there, but the floor stands mostly dark. He runs along the carpet, passing silent offices, a conference room, a break room, a library. The hallway finally opens into a reception area that’s paired with the largest office.

In the dim light, the details are all in shades of gray. A sprawling mahogany desk buried under files and paperwork. A circular table covered in notepads and mugs of cold, bitter-smelling coffee. A wet bar stocked exclusively with bottles of Macallan Rare. A glowing aquarium that hums on the far side of the room and contains a small shark and several tropical fish.

As Barry approaches the French doors, he silences his phone and removes his shoes. Taking the handle, he eases the door open and slips out onto the terrace.

The surrounding skyscrapers of the Upper West Side look mystical in their luminous shrouds of fog. The noise of the city is loud and close—car horns ricocheting between the buildings and distant ambulances racing toward some other tragedy. The pinnacle of the Poe Building is less than fifty feet above—a crown of glass and steel and gothic masonry.

The woman sits fifteen feet away beside an eroding gargoyle, her back to Barry, her legs dangling over the edge.

He inches closer, the wet flagstones soaking through his socks. If he can get close enough without detection, he'll drag her off the edge before she knows what—

"I smell your cologne," she says without looking back.

He stops.

She looks back at him, says, "Another step and I'm gone."

It's difficult to tell in the ambient light, but she appears to be in the vicinity of forty. She wears a dark blazer and matching skirt, and she must have been sitting out here for a while, because her hair has been flattened by the mist.

"Who are you?" she asks.

"Barry Sutton. I'm a detective in the Central Robbery Division of NYPD."

"They sent someone from the Robbery—?"

"I happened to be closest. What's your name?"

"Ann Voss Peters."

"May I call you Ann?"

"Sure."

"Is there anyone I can call for you?"

She shakes her head.

"I'm going to step over here so you don't have to keep straining your neck to look at me."

Barry moves away from her at an angle that also brings him to

the parapet, eight feet down from where she's sitting. He glances once over the edge, his insides contracting.

"All right, let's hear it," she says.

"I'm sorry?"

"Aren't you here to talk me off? Give it your best shot."

He decided what he would say riding up in the elevator, recalling his suicide training. Now, squarely in the moment, he feels less confident. The only thing he's sure of is that his feet are freezing.

"I know everything feels hopeless to you in this moment, but this is just a moment, and moments pass."

Ann stares straight down the side of the building, four hundred feet to the street below, her palms flat against the stone that has been weathered by decades of acid rain. All she would have to do is push off. He suspects she's walking herself through the motions, tiptoeing up to the thought of doing it. Amassing that final head of steam.

He notices she's shivering.

"May I give you my jacket?" he asks.

"I'm pretty sure you don't want to come any closer, Detective."

"Why is that?"

"I have FMS."

Barry resists the urge to run. Of course he's heard of False Memory Syndrome, but he's never known or met someone with the affliction. Never breathed the same air. He isn't sure he should attempt to grab her now. Doesn't even want to be this close. No, fuck that. If she moves to jump, he'll try to save her, and if he contracts FMS in the process, so be it. That's the risk you take becoming a cop.

"How long have you had it?" he asks.

"One morning, about a month ago, instead of my home in Middlebury, Vermont, I was suddenly in an apartment here in the city, with a stabbing pain in my head and a terrible nosebleed. At first, I had no idea where I was. Then I remembered . . . *this* life too. Here and now, I'm single, an investment banker, I live under my maiden name. But I have . . ."—she visibly braces herself against the

emotion—"memories of my other life in Vermont. I was a mother to a nine-year-old boy named Sam. I ran a landscaping business with my husband, Joe Behrman. I was Ann Behrman. We were as happy as anyone has a right to be."

"What does it feel like?" Barry asks, taking a clandestine step closer.

"What does what feel like?"

"Your false memories of this Vermont life."

"I don't just remember my wedding. I remember the fight over the design for the cake. I remember the smallest details of our home. Our son. Every moment of his birth. His laugh. The birthmark on his left cheek. His first day of school and how he didn't want me to leave him. But when I try to picture Sam, he's in black and white. There's no color in his eyes. I tell myself they were blue. I only see black.

"All my memories from that life are in shades of gray, like film noir stills. They feel real, but they're haunted, phantom memories." She breaks down. "Everyone thinks FMS is just false memories of the big moments of your life, but what hurts so much more are the small ones. I don't just remember my husband. I remember the smell of his breath in the morning when he rolled over and faced me in bed. How every time he got up before I did to brush his teeth, I knew he'd come back to bed and try to have sex. That's the stuff that kills me. The tiniest, perfect details that make me know it happened."

"What about this life?" Barry asks. "Isn't it worth something to you?"

"Maybe some people get FMS and prefer their current memories to their false ones, but there's nothing about this life I want. I've tried, for four long weeks. I can't fake it anymore." Tears carve trails through her eyeliner. "My son never existed. Do you get that? He's just a beautiful misfire in my brain."

Barry ventures another step toward her, but she catches him this time.

"Don't come any closer."

"You are not alone."

"I am very fucking alone."

"I've only known you a few minutes, and I will be devastated if you do this. Think about the people in your life who love you. Think how they'll feel."

"I tracked Joe down," Ann says.

"Who?"

"My husband. He was living in a mansion out on Long Island. He acted like he didn't recognize me, but I know he did. He had a whole other life. He was married—I don't know to who. I don't know if he had kids. He acted like *I* was crazy."

"I'm sorry, Ann."

"This hurts too much."

"Look, I've been where you are. I've wanted to end everything. And I'm standing here right now telling you I'm glad I didn't. I'm glad I had the strength to ride it out. This low point isn't the book of your life. It's just a chapter."

"What happened to you?"

"I lost my daughter. Life has broken my heart too."

Ann looks at the incandescent skyline. "Do you have photos of her? Do you still talk with people about her?"

"Yes."

"At least she once existed."

There is simply nothing he can say to that.

Ann looks down through her legs again. She kicks off one of her pumps.

Watches it fall.

Then sends the other one plummeting after it.

"Ann, please."

"In my previous life, my false life, Joe's first wife, Franny, jumped from this building, from this ledge actually, fifteen years ago. She had clinical depression. I know he blamed himself. Before I left his house on Long Island, I told Joe I was going to jump from the Poe

Building tonight, just like Franny. It sounds silly and desperate, but I hoped he'd show up here tonight and save me. Like he failed to do for her. At first, I thought you might be him, but he never wore cologne." She smiles—wistful—then adds, "I'm thirsty."

Barry glances through the French doors and the dark office, sees two patrolmen standing at the ready by the reception desk. He looks back at Ann. "Then why don't you climb down from there, and we'll walk inside together and get you a glass of water."

"Would you bring it to me out here?"

"I can't leave you."

Her hands are shaking now, and he registers a sudden resolve in her eyes.

She looks at Barry. "This isn't your fault," she says. "It was always going to end this way."

"Ann, no—"

"My son has been erased."

And with a casual grace, she eases herself off the edge.

HELENA

October 22, 2007

Standing in the shower at six a.m., trying to wake up as the hot water sluices down her skin, Helena is struck with an intense sensation of having lived this exact moment before. It's nothing new. Déjà vu has plagued her since her twenties. Besides, there's nothing particularly special about this moment in the shower. She's wondering if Mountainside Capital has reviewed her proposal yet. It's been a week. She should've heard something by now. They should've at least called her in for a meeting if they were interested.

She brews a pot of coffee and makes her go-to breakfast—black

beans, three eggs over-easy, drizzled with ketchup. Sits at the little table by the window, watching the sky fill with light over her neighborhood on the outskirts of San Jose.

She hasn't had a day to do laundry in over a month, and the floor of her bedroom is practically carpeted in dirty clothes. She digs through the piles until she finds a T-shirt and a pair of jeans she isn't totally ashamed to leave the house in.

The phone rings while she's brushing her teeth. She spits, rinses, and catches the call on the fourth ring in her bedroom.

"How's my girl?"

Her father's voice always makes her smile.

"Hey, Dad."

"I thought I'd missed you. I didn't want to bother you at the lab."

"No, it's fine, what's up?"

"Just thinking about you. Any word on your proposal?"

"Nothing yet."

"I have a really good feeling it's going to happen."

"I don't know. This is a tough town. Lots of competition. Lots of really smart people looking for money."

"But not as smart as my girl."

She can't take any more of her father's belief in her. Not on a morning like this, with the specter of failure looming large, sitting in a small, filthy bedroom of a blank-walled, undecorated house where she has not brought a single person in over a year.

"How's the weather?" she asks to change the subject.

"Snowed last night. First of the season."

"A lot?"

"Just an inch or two. But the mountains are white."

She can picture them—the Front Range of the Rockies, the mountains of her childhood.

"How's Mom?"

There's the briefest pause.

"Your mother's doing well."

"Dad."

"What?"

"How's Mom?"

She hears him exhale slowly. "We've had better days."

"Is she OK?"

"Yes. She's upstairs sleeping right now."

"What happened?"

"It's nothing."

"Tell me."

"Last night, we played gin rummy after dinner, like we always do. And she just . . . she didn't know the rules anymore. Sat at the kitchen table, staring at her cards, tears running down her face. We've been playing together for thirty years."

She hears his hand cover the receiver.

He's crying, a thousand miles away.

"Dad, I'm coming home."

"No, Helena."

"You need my help."

"We have good support here. We're going to the doctor this afternoon. If you want to help your mother, get your funding and build your chair."

She doesn't want to tell him, but the chair is still years away. *Light-years* away. It's a dream, a mirage.

Her eyes fill with tears. "You know I'm doing this for her."

"I know, sweetheart."

For a moment, they're both quiet, trying to cry without the other knowing, and failing miserably. She wants nothing more than to tell him it's going to happen, but that would be a lie.

"I'm going to call when I get home tonight," she says.

"OK."

"Please tell Mom I love her."

"I will. But she already knows."

Four hours later, deep in the neuroscience building in Palo Alto, Helena is examining the image of a mouse's memory of being afraid—fluorescently illuminated neurons interconnected by a spiderweb of synapses—when the stranger appears in her office doorway. She looks over the top of her monitor at a man dressed in chinos and a white T-shirt, with a smile several shades too bright.

"Helena Smith?" he asks.

"Yes?"

"I'm Jee-woon Chercover. Do you have a minute to speak with me?"

"This is a secure lab. You're not supposed to be down here."

"I apologize for the intrusion, but I think you'll want to hear what I have to say."

She could ask him to leave, or call security. But he doesn't look threatening.

"OK," she says, and it suddenly dawns on her that this man is bearing witness to the hoarder's dream that is her office—windowless, cramped, painted-over cinder-block walls, everything only made more claustrophobic by the bankers' boxes stacked three feet high and two deep around her desk, filled with thousands of abstracts and articles. "Sorry about the mess. Let me get you a chair."

"I got it."

Jee-woon drags a folding chair over and takes a seat across from her, his eyes passing over the walls, which are nearly covered in high-resolution images of mouse memories and the neuronal firings of dementia and Alzheimer's patients.

"What can I do for you?" she asks.

"My employer is very taken with the memory portraiture article you published in *Neuron*."

"Does your employer have a name?"

"Well, that depends."

"On . . . ?"

"How this conversation goes."

"Why would I even have a conversation with someone when I don't know who they're speaking for?"

"Because your Stanford money runs out in six weeks."

She raises an eyebrow.

He says, "My boss pays me very well to know everything about the people he finds interesting."

"You do realize what you just said is totally creepy, right?"

Reaching into his leather satchel, Jee-woon takes out a document in a navy binder.

Her proposal.

"Of course!" she says. "You're with Mountainside Capital!"

"No. And they're not going to fund you."

"Then how did you get that?"

"It doesn't matter. No one is going to fund you."

"How do you know?"

"Because this?" He tosses her grant proposal onto the wreckage of her desk. "Is timid. It's just more of what you've been doing at Stanford the last three years. It's not big-idea enough. You're thirty-eight years old, which is like ninety in academia. One morning in the not-too-distant future, you're going to wake up and realize your best days are behind you. That you wasted—"

"I think you should leave."

"I don't mean to insult you. If you don't mind my saying, your problem is that you're afraid to ask for what you really want." It occurs to her that, for some reason, this stranger is trolling her. She knows she shouldn't continue to engage, but she can't help herself.

"And why am I afraid to ask for what I really want?"

"Because what you really want is bank-breaking. You don't need seven figures. You need nine. Maybe ten. You need a team of coders to help you design an algorithm for complex memory cataloging and projection. The infrastructure for human trials."

She stares at him across the desk. "I never mentioned human trials in that proposal."

"What if I were to tell you that we will give you anything you ask for? No-limit funding. Would you be interested?"

Her heart is beating faster and faster.

Is this how it happens?

She thinks of the fifty-million-dollar chair she has dreamed of building since her mom started to forget life. Strangely, she never imagines it fully rendered, only as the technical drawings in the utility patent application she will one day file, entitled *Immersive Platform for Projection of Long-Term, Explicit, Episodic Memories*.

"Helena?"

"If I say yes, will you tell me who your boss is?"

"Yes."

"Yes."

He tells her.

As her jaw hits the desk, Jee-woon pulls another document out of his satchel and passes it to her over the bankers' boxes.

"What's this?" she asks.

"An employment and confidentiality agreement. Nonnegotiable. I think you'll find the financial terms to be very generous."

BARRY

November 4, 2018

The café occupies a picturesque spot on the banks of the Hudson, in the shadow of the West Side Highway. Barry arrives five minutes early to find Julia already seated at a table under an umbrella. They share a brief, fragile embrace, as if they're both made of glass.

"It's good to see you," he says.

"I'm glad you wanted to come."

They sit. A waiter swings by to take their drink orders.

"How's Anthony?" Barry asks.

"Great. Busy with the redesign of the Lewis Building lobby. Your work's good?"

He doesn't tell her about the suicide he failed to stop the night before last. Instead, they make small talk until the coffee arrives.

It's Sunday, and the brunch crowd is out in force. Every table in the vicinity seems to be a geyser of gregarious conversation and laughter, but they sip their coffees quietly in the shade.

Nothing and everything to say.

A butterfly flutters around Barry's head until he gently brushes it away.

Sometimes, late in the night, he imagines elaborate conversations with Julia. Exchanges where he says everything that has been festering all these years in his heart—the pain, the anger, the love—and then listens as she does the same. A clearing of air to the point where he finally understands her and she understands him.

But in person, it never feels right. He can't bring himself to say what's in his heart, which always feels clenched and locked up, encased in scar tissue. The awkwardness doesn't bother him like it used to. He has made peace with the idea that part of life is facing your failures, and sometimes those failures are people you once loved.

"I wonder what she'd be doing today," Julia says.

"I hope she'd be sitting here with us."

"I mean for work."

"Ah. A lawyer of course."

Julia laughs—one of the greatest sounds he's ever encountered—and he can't remember the last time he heard it. Beautiful but also crushing to experience. Like a secret window into the person he used to know.

"She would argue about anything," Julia says. "And she usually won."

"We were pushovers."

"One of us was."

"Me?" he says with faux outrage.

"By five years old, she had you pegged as the weak link."

"Remember the time she convinced us to let her practice backing up in the driveway—"

"Convinced you."

"—and she drove my car through the garage door?"

Julia snorts a laugh. "She was so upset."

"No, embarrassed." For a half second, his mind's eye conjures the memory. Or at least a piece of it. Meghan behind the wheel of his old Camry, the back half punched through the garage door, her face red and tears streaming down it as she white-knuckle-clenched the steering wheel. "She was tenacious and smart and would've done something interesting with her life." He finishes his coffee and pours another cup from the stainless-steel French press they're sharing.

"It's nice to talk about her," Julia says.

"I'm glad I finally can."

The waiter comes to take their food orders, and the butterfly returns, alighting on the surface of the table next to Barry's still-folded napkin. Stretching its wings. Preening. He tries to push the idea out of his mind that it's Meghan, somehow haunting him on today of all days. It's a stupid notion, of course, but the thought persists. Like the time a robin followed him for eight blocks in NoHo. Or on a recent walk with his dog in Fort Washington Park, when a ladybug kept landing on his wrist.

As the food arrives, Barry imagines Meghan sitting at the table with them. The rough edges of adolescence sanded down. Her entire life ahead of her. He can't see her face, no matter how hard he tries, only her hands, in constant motion as she talks, the same way her mother moves when she's confident and excited about something.

He isn't hungry, but he makes himself eat. It seems like there's something on Julia's mind, but she just picks at the remains of her frittata, and he takes a drink of water and another bite of his sandwich and stares at the river in the distance.

The Hudson comes from a pond in the Adirondacks called Lake Tear of the Clouds. They went there one summer when Meghan was eight or nine. Camped in the spruce trees. Watched the stars fall. Tried to wrap their minds around the notion that this tiny mountain lake was the source of the Hudson. It's a memory he returns to almost obsessively.

"You look thoughtful," Julia says.

"I was thinking of that trip we took to Lake Tear of the Clouds. Remember?"

"Of course. It took us two hours to get the tent up in a rainstorm."

"I thought it was clear."

She shakes her head. "No, we shivered in the tent all night and none of us slept."

"You sure about that?"

"Yes. That trip was the foundation of my never-again wilderness policy."

"Right."

"How could you forget that?"

"I don't know." The truth is he does it constantly. He is always looking back, living more in memories than the present, often altering them to make them prettier. To make them perfect. Nostalgia is as much an analgesic for him as alcohol. He says finally, "Maybe watching shooting stars with my girls felt like a better memory."

She tosses her napkin on her plate and leans back in her chair. "I went by our old house recently. Wow, it's changed. You ever do that?"

"Every now and then."

In actuality, he still drives past their old house anytime he has business in Jersey. He and Julia lost it in a foreclosure the year after Meghan died, and today it barely resembles the place they lived in. The trees are taller, fuller, greener. There's an addition above the garage, and a young family lives there now. The entire façade has been redone in stone, new windows added. The driveway widened and repaved. The rope swing that used to hang from the oak tree was taken down years ago, but the initials he and Meghan once

carved at the base of the trunk remain. He touched them last summer—having somehow decided that a cab ride to Jersey at two in the morning after a night out with Gwen and the rest of Central Robbery Division was a good idea. A Jersey City cop had arrived after the new owners called 911 to report a vagrant in their front yard. Though stumbling drunk, he wasn't arrested. The cop knew of Barry, of what had happened to him. He called another taxi and helped Barry into the backseat. Paid the fare back to Manhattan in advance and sent him on his way.

The breeze coming off the water carries a cool bite, and the sun is warm on his shoulders—a pleasing contrast. Tourist boats go up and down the river. The noise of traffic is ceaseless on the highway above. The sky crisscrossed with the fading contrails of a thousand jets. It is late autumn in the city, one of the last good days of the year.

He thinks how it will be winter soon, and then another year gone by and another one on the chopping block, time flowing faster and faster. Life is nothing how he expected it would be when he was young and living under the delusion that things could be controlled. Nothing can be controlled. Only endured.

The check comes and Julia tries to pay, but he snatches it away and throws down his card.

"Thank you, Barry."

"Thank you for inviting me."

"Let's not go a year again without seeing each other." She raises her glass of ice water. "To our birthday girl."

"To our birthday girl." He can feel the cloud of grief coalescing in his chest, but he breathes through it, and when he speaks again his voice is almost normal. "Twenty-six years old."

After brunch, he walks to Central Park. The silence of his apartment feels like a threat on Meghan's birthday, the last five of which have not gone well.

Seeing Julia always upends him. For a long time after their marriage ended, he thought he missed his ex. Thought he would never get over her. He would often dream of her and wake to the ache of her absence eating him alive. The dreams cut him deeply—half memory, half fantasy—because in them, she felt like the Julia of old. The smile. The unhesitating laugh. The lightness of being. She was the person who stole his heart again. All through the following morning, she'd be on his mind, the totality of that loss staring him down, unblinking, until the emotional hangover of the dream finally released its hold on him like a slowly lifting fog. He saw Julia once, in the wake of one such dream—an unexpected bump-in at the party of an old friend. To his surprise, he felt nothing as they chatted stiffly on the veranda. Being in her presence slashed through the dream-withdrawal; he didn't want her. It was a liberating revelation, even as it devastated him. Liberating because it meant he didn't love this Julia—he loved the person she used to be. Devastating because the woman who haunted his dreams was truly gone. As unreachable as the dead.

The trees in the park are peaking after a hard freeze several nights ago, the leaves all frost-burned into late autumn brilliance.

He finds a spot in the Ramble, takes off his shoes and socks, and leans back against a perfectly slanted tree. He pulls out his phone and tries to read the biography he's been plodding through for nearly a year, but concentration is elusive.

Ann Voss Peters haunts him. The way she fell without a sound, her body rigid and upright. It took five seconds, and he didn't look away when she hit the Lincoln Town Car, parked on the curb below.

When he isn't replaying their conversation, he's grappling with the fear. Pressure-checking his memories. Testing their fidelity. Wondering—

How would I know if one had changed? What would it feel like?

Red and orange leaves drift down through the sunlight, accumulating all around him in the dappled shade. From his vantage

in the trees, he watches people walking the trails, moseying by the lake. Most are with others, but some are alone like him.

His phone pops a text from his friend Gwendoline Archer, leader of the Hercules Team, a counterterrorism SWAT unit in the NYPD's Emergency Service Unit.

Thinking about you today. You OK?

He writes her back:

Yeah. Just saw Julia.

How was that?

Good. Hard. What are you up to?

Just finished a ride. Drinking at

Isaac's. Want some company?

God yes. OMW.

It's a forty-minute walk to the bar near Gwen's apartment in Hell's Kitchen, whose only apparent virtue is its forty-five-year longevity. Prickly bartenders serve boring domestics on tap and not a single whiskey whose bottle you couldn't buy in a store for under thirty bucks. The bathrooms are disgusting and still contain stocked condom dispensers. The jukebox plays '70s and '80s rock exclusively, and if no one feeds the box, there is no music.

Gwen is sitting at the far end of the bar, wearing biker shorts and a faded Brooklyn Marathon T-shirt, left-swiping on a dating app as Barry approaches.

He says, "I thought you gave up on that."

"For a while, I gave up on your gender entirely, but my therapist is all the way up my ass to try again."

She slides off the stool and embraces him, the faint smell of sweat from her ride combining with the remnants of body wash and deodorant, resulting in something like a salted caramel.

He says, "Thanks for checking in on me."

"You shouldn't be alone today."

She's fifteen years younger, in her mid-thirties, and at six feet, four inches, the tallest woman he knows personally. With short blond hair and Scandinavian features, she's not beautiful exactly, but regal. Often severe without trying. He once told her she had resting monarch face.

They met and bonded during a bank robbery turned hostage situation a few years back. The next Christmas, they hooked up in one of the more embarrassing moments of Barry's existence. It was one of the many NYPD holiday parties, and the night had gotten away from them both. He woke in her apartment at three in the morning with the room still spinning. His mistake was trying to sneak out when he wasn't ready for consciousness. He threw up on the floor beside her bed, and was in the midst of trying to clean it up when Gwen woke and yelled at him, "I will clean up your puke in the morning, just go!" He remembers nothing of the sex, if they had it or attempted to, and he can only hope she shares the same merciful gap in her memory.

Regardless, neither of them has acknowledged it since.

The bartender arrives to take Barry's order and deliver another Wild Turkey to Gwen. They drink and bullshit for a while, and as Barry finally registers the world beginning to loosen, Gwen says, "I heard you caught an FMS suicide Friday night."

"Yeah."

He fills her in on all the details.

"Be honest," she says. "How freaked out are you?"

"Well, I did make myself an Internet expert on FMS yesterday."

"And?"

"Eight months ago, the Centers for Disease Control identified sixty-four cases with similarities in the Northeast. In each case, a patient presented with complaints of acute false memories. Not just one or two. A fully imagined alternate history covering large swaths of their life up until that moment. Usually going back months or years. In some instances, decades."

“So do they lose their memories of their real life?”

“No, they suddenly have *two sets* of memories. One true, one false. In some cases, patients felt like their memories and consciousness had moved from one life into another. In others, patients experienced a sudden ‘flash-in’ of false memories from a life they never lived.”

“What causes it?”

“Nobody knows. They haven’t identified a single physiological or neurological abnormality in those who are affected. The only symptoms are the false memories themselves. Oh, and about ten percent of people who get it kill themselves.”

“Jesus.”

“The number could be higher. Way higher. That’s the outcome of known cases.”

“Suicides are up this year in the five boroughs.”

Barry catches the bartender’s eye, gives the signal for another round.

Gwen asks, “Contagious?”

“I couldn’t find a definitive answer. The CDC hasn’t found a pathogen, so it doesn’t seem to be blood- or airborne. Yet. This article in *The New England Journal of Medicine* speculated that it actually spreads through a carrier’s social network.”

“Like Facebook? How is that even—”

“No, I mean when a person is infected with FMS, some of the people they know become infected. Their parents will share the same false memories, but to a lesser degree. Their brothers, sisters, close friends. There was this case study of a guy who woke up one day and had memories of an entirely different life. Being married to a different woman. Living in a different house, with different kids, working a different job. They reconstructed from his memory the guest list of his wedding—the one that he remembered, but never happened. They located thirteen from his list, and all of them also had memories of this wedding that never happened. Ever hear of something called the Mandela Effect?”

"I don't know. Maybe."

The next round comes. Barry drinks his shot of Old Grand-Dad and chases it with a Coors as the light through the front windows fades toward evening.

He says, "Apparently thousands of people remember Nelson Mandela dying in prison in the 1980s, even though he lived until 2013."

"I have heard of this. It's the whole Berenstain Bears thing."

"I don't know what that is."

"You're too old."

"Fuck you."

"There were these children's books when I was a kid, and a lot of people remember them being called *The Berenstain Bears*, S-T-E-I-N, when it's actually spelled Berenstain. S-T-A-I-N."

"Weird."

"Scary actually, since I remember Berenstain." Gwen shoots her whiskey.

"Also—and no one's sure if it's related to FMS—instances of acute déjà vu are on the rise."

"What does that mean?"

"People are struck, sometimes to a debilitating degree, with the sense that they're living entire sequences of their lives over."

"I get that sometimes."

"Me too."

Gwen says, "Didn't your jumper say that her husband's first wife had also thrown herself off the Poe Building?"

"Yeah, why?"

"I don't know. Just seems . . . unlikely."

Barry looks at her. The bar is getting full and loud.

"What are you getting at?" he asks.

"Maybe she didn't have False Memory Syndrome. Maybe this bitch was just crazy. Maybe don't worry so much."

Three hours later, he's wasted in a different bar—a wood-paneled, beer-lover's wet dream with the taxidermied heads of buffalo and deer protruding from the walls and a million taps lining the backlit shelves.

Gwen tries to take him to dinner, but the hostess sees him wavering on his feet in front of her podium and refuses them a table. Back outside, the city feels unmoored, and Barry is laser-focused on making the buildings not spin as Gwen holds him by his right arm, steering him down the street.

He suddenly realizes they're standing on a street corner God-knows-where, speaking to a cop. Gwen is showing the patrolman her star and explaining that she's trying to get Barry home but is afraid he'll throw up in a cab.

Then they're walking again, stumbling, the futuristic, nighttime brilliance of Times Square swirling like a bad carnival. He catches the time, 11:22 p.m., and wonders what black hole the last six hours fell into.

"I don't wannagohome," he says to no one.

Then he's staring at a digital clock that reads 4:15. It feels like someone caved his skull in while he slept, and his tongue is as dry as a strip of leather. This isn't his apartment. He's lying on the sofa in Gwen's living room.

He tries to go back and Scotch-tape the evening together but the pieces are shattered. He remembers Julia and the park. The first hour of the first bar with Gwen. But everything after is murky and tinged with regret.

His heart pounds in his ears. His mind races.

It is the lonely hour of the night, one with which he is all too familiar—when the city sleeps but you don't, and all the regrets of your life rage in your mind with an unbearable intensity.

Thinking about his father who died when he was young, and the enduring question—*Did he know that I loved him?*

And Meghan. Always Meghan.

When his daughter was a little girl, she was convinced a monster

lived in the hope chest at the foot of her bed. It never crossed her mind in the daylight, but the moment the sun went down and he had tucked her in for the night, she would inevitably call out for him. And he'd hurry to her room and kneel beside her bed and remind her that everything seems scarier at night. It's just an illusion. A trick the darkness plays on us.

How strange then, decades later and his life so far off the course he charted, to find himself alone on a couch in a friend's apartment, attempting to assuage his fears with the same logic he used on his child all those years ago.

Everything will look better in the morning.

There will be hope again when the light returns.

The despair is only an illusion, a trick the darkness plays.

And he shuts his eyes and comforts himself with the memory of the camping trip to Lake Tear of the Clouds. To that perfect moment.

In it, the stars were shining.

He'd stay there forever if he could.

HELENA

November 1, 2007

Day 1

Her stomach is in knots as she watches the Northern California coastline dwindling away. She's sitting behind the pilot, under the roar of the rotors, watching the ocean stream beneath her, five hundred feet below the helicopter skids.

It is not a good day at sea. The clouds drape low; the water is gray and specked with whitecaps. And the farther from land they go, the darker the world becomes.

Through the helicopter's rain-streaked windshield, she sees

something materializing in the distance—a structure jutting out of the water, still a mile or two away.

She says into her microphone, “Is that it?”

“Yes ma’am.”

Leaning forward against the shoulder harness, she watches with intense curiosity as the chopper begins its approach, slowing now, descending toward a colossus of iron, steel, and concrete that stands on three legs in the ocean like a giant tripod. The pilot pushes the stick and they bank left into a slow circle around the structure, whose main platform sits approximately twenty stories above the sea. A few cranes still overhang the sides—relics from the oil- and gas-drilling days. But otherwise, the rig has been stripped of its industrial trappings and transformed. On the primary platform, she sees a full basketball court. Swimming pool. Greenhouse. What appears to be a running track around the perimeter.

They land on a helipad. The turbo shaft begins to wind down, and through her window, Helena watches a man in a yellow bomber jacket jogging toward the helicopter. As he opens the cabin door, she fumbles with the three-point locking mechanism on her restraints until they finally unlatch.

The man helps her out of the chopper, down onto the skid, and then the landing surface. She follows him toward a set of stairs that descends from the helipad onto the main platform. The wind rips through her hoodie and T-shirt, and as she reaches the steps, the sound of the helicopter dies away, leaving the gaping silence of the open ocean.

They come off the last step onto a sprawling concrete surface, and there he is, moving toward them across the platform.

Her heart kicks.

His beard is unkempt, his dark hair wild and blowing in the wind. He is wearing a pair of blue jeans and a faded sweatshirt, and he is unmistakably Marcus Slade—inventor, philanthropist, business magnate, founder of more groundbreaking technology companies than she can name, touching sectors as diverse as cloud

computing, transportation, space, and AI. He is one of the world's richest, most influential citizens. A high-school dropout. And only thirty-four years old.

He smiles and says, "We're doing this!"

His enthusiasm calms her nerves, and as they reach each other on the platform, she's unsure what's called for. A handshake? Polite hug? Slade makes the choice for her with a warm embrace.

"Welcome to Fawkes Station."

"Fawkes?"

"As in Guy Fawkes—remember, remember the fifth of November?"

"Oh. Right. Because memory?"

"Because disrupting the status quo is kind of my thing. You must be cold, let's get you inside." They're moving now, heading toward a five-story superstructure on the far side of the platform.

"Not quite what I was expecting," Helena says.

"I bought it a few years ago from ExxonMobil when the oil field ran dry. At first I was going to make this a new home for myself."

"You mean a fortress of solitude?"

"Totally. But then I realized I could live here and also use it as the perfect research facility."

"Why perfect?"

"A million reasons, but the most critical are privacy and security. I have my hands in a number of fields that are rife with corporate espionage, and this is about as controllable an environment as you can get, right?"

They pass the swimming pool, covered for the season, the tarp flapping violently in the November wind.

She says, "First off, thank you. Secondly, why me?"

"Because inside your head is a technology that could alter humanity."

"How so?"

"What's more precious than our memories?" he asks. "They define us and form our identities."

“Also, there will be a fifteen-billion-dollar market for Alzheimer’s treatments in the next decade.”

Marcus only smiles.

She says, “Just so you know, my primary goal is to help people. I want to find a way to save memories for deteriorating brains that can no longer retrieve them. A time capsule for core memories.”

“I hear that. Can you think of any reason this can’t be both a philanthropic and commercial endeavor?”

They pass the entrance to a large greenhouse, the walls inside steamed and dripping with condensation.

“How far offshore are we?” she asks, looking across the platform out to sea, where a dense cloud is rolling toward them.

“One hundred seventy-three miles. How’d your family and friends take the news that you were falling off the face of the Earth to do some super-secret research?”

She isn’t sure how to answer that. Her life as of late has unspooled under the fluorescent lights of laboratories and revolved around the processing of raw data. She has never managed to achieve escape velocity from the irresistible gravity of her work—for her mom, but if she’s honest, also for herself. Work is the only thing that makes her feel alive, and she’s wondered, on more than one occasion, if that means she’s broken.

“I work a lot,” she says, “so I only had six people to tell. My dad cried, but he always cries. No one was really surprised. God, that sounds pathetic, doesn’t it?”

Slade looks at her, says, “I think balance is for people who don’t know why they’re here.”

She considers that. In high school, in college, she was encouraged again and again to find her passion—a reason to get out of bed and breathe. In her experience, few people ever found that *raison d’être*.

What teachers and professors never told her was about the dark side of finding your purpose. The part where it consumes you. Where it becomes a destroyer of relationships and happiness. And

still, she wouldn't trade it. This is the only person she knows how to be.

They're approaching the entrance to the superstructure.

"Hold up a second," Slade says. "Watch." He points toward the wall of mist as it plows across the platform. The air becomes cold and silent. Helena can't even see to the helipad. They're caught in the heart of a cloud.

Slade looks at her. "Do you want to change the world with me?"

"That's why I'm here."

"Good. Let's go see what I've built for you."

The Birthday Girl
Melissa de la Cruz

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MELISSA DE LA CRUZ



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Part One

FALSE STARTS

ONE

Last-Minute Preparations

October 19

The Present

5:00 PM

Ellie de Florent-Stinson had made a point of telling everyone she knew that she'd bought the house in Palm Springs for her birthday, as a *gift to self*.

Renting a Palm Springs house for a celebration was practically a rite of passage among a certain Los Angeles set, a flurry of Paperless Post invites with the requisite Rat-Pack-in-the-desert themes landing in one's inbox with a predictable thud over the years.

But Ellie always had to one-up, take it to the next mile, power it beyond the goalpost and smash it on the turf while doing an illegal victory dance—so she had actually *bought* a house, for a little over two million. Renting was so bourgeois.

Her phone had been blowing up with texts from excited friends for weeks.

Melissa de la Cruz

Can't wait!!!

Me too!!

What should I bring??

Ellie snorted. This was no potluck. She texted, Yourself!

It was going to be perfect. Her fortieth birthday blowout at her new mid-century-modern pad that night was the *pièce de résistance*. She'd flown in the designer of her favorite Parisian hotels to turn a neighboring farm-to-table (or weeds-to-shithole as her husband joked) restaurant into a louche nineteenth-century Chinese opium den for the decadent after-*after*-party. (The *first* after-party would be held at the Ace Hotel's infamous Drag Queen Bingo *bien sûr*.) The designer had arrived the week before with real persimmons in tow (two euros each at the farmers market in Clignancourt) to hang from the newly bejeweled rafters. For the past two days, her guests had enjoyed guided spirit walks, hot yoga, mindfulness, tarot, and the Parker's two hot tubs. She'd flown in the majority of the motley crew from New York on Thursday night via YourJet, the semiprivate charter service app. The three-day event had been arranged down to every last detail—she'd even coerced a new acquaintance, a prize-winning novelist, to help write the children's loving speeches to her.

The party at her new home, Gulf House (so named because its original owner was said to have been the CEO of Gulfstream), was the icing on the cake, the cherry on the sundae, the culmination of a yearlong bacchanalian observance of the commencement of her fourth decade on the planet.

Except nothing was going the way she'd planned.

The hydrangeas were wilting and it was only five o'clock, an hour before her first guests were due to arrive. Fully half the flowers had died from exposure to the harsh desert climate. Of course it was Ellie's fault: She'd insisted on the fragile posies, over the objections of her party planner and local florist, who had warned her that only sunflowers would be able to survive the desert heat. Ellie had nixed sunflowers as cheap, and so had to contend with the reality of the dead white blossoms. She wanted to scream, but instead texted Nathaniel, her long-suffering twentysomething assistant: THE!!! FLOWERS!! ARE!!! DYING!!!!!! FIX IT!!!!!!

Who knew October in Palm Springs would be as hot as Phoenix in July? Not Ellie. It was a goddamn one hundred ten degrees out, and even with the cloud of misters over the pool going at full blast, there was no denying it was as hot as Satan's armpit in the backyard. She took some consolation in the postcard-perfect golf course view, the sky a brilliant blue overhead. Plus, once the sun had set—four hours from now—it would be bearable. Right?

The house was situated in the south end of Palm Springs, in the old Canyon Country Club neighborhood, which was now called Indian Canyons because the land was leased from the tribe that owned it. Half the city sat on Native American land, hence the presence of casinos downtown. But Ellie insisted on calling it by its original name—the name of the country club when Frank Sinatra and Walt Disney used to golf there. If she'd been on the city council, she never would have allowed the name change. The older families bunkered down in the Vista Los Palmas neighborhood on the north end, which was supposedly more desirable because it wasn't leased land. But it was windy over there, and the

views of the mountains were better on the south side of town. She'd fallen in love with her neighborhood's wide streets dotted with palm trees. Here in Indian Canyons, the homes weren't hidden behind high hedges or walls, so everyone could see exactly how fabulous your house was.

Ellie could have bought in the neighboring desert city of Rancho Mirage, in the swank confines of Thunderbird, where Gerald Ford famously retired and Barack and Michelle Obama were rumored to have bought a vacation home. But Rancho struck her as one gated community after another, soulless, moneyed, and modern, whereas Palm Springs proper had a certain old-fashioned cachet, a star-dusting of Hollywood history. The house was on a double corner lot and had practically a three-hundred-sixty-degree view of the golf course and the San Jacinto mountain range. She'd fallen in love the minute she walked through its double-height double doors painted in a cheery yellow, almost exactly three months ago.

"The second DJ is here," announced Lynn, her housekeeper from Los Angeles who'd agreed to work the weekend and who was plucking out dead hydrangeas from the floral arrangements and making them look lopsided. "Where should we put him?"

"In the game room," she replied.

"*Second* DJ?" asked her husband, Todd, walking into the terrazzo-floored living room and rolling his eyes. "Do we have *two* catering companies too? Or five? How many people are coming tonight anyway?"

"A bunch," she said airily. Ellie tried never to answer his questions directly. *How much was that handbag/bracelet/haircut/second*

house? “A lot.” *Where are you going?* “Out.” *What time will you be home?* “Later.”

They’d been in love, once. They even used to have sex—remember sex? Sure, married sex and all the lameness that phrase implied—hurried-before-the-kids-got-up or fatigued-after-the-kids-went-to-sleep kind of sex, but now she couldn’t even remember the last time they’d done the deed. No wonder she was so uptight. It was ten years since that weekend in St. Barts when they’d pledged their trough—or was it *troth*? A trough was the thing pigs ate from, she thought. Although perhaps *trough* was the more appropriate word, now that Todd had gained fifty pounds after going on antianxiety, antidepression, anti-everything meds. Paging Todd’s libido! Or maybe it wasn’t the meds at all; just because he wasn’t sleeping with *her* didn’t mean he wasn’t sleeping *around*, did it?

Did she even care if he was?

There they were, captured in that photograph in a silver frame resting on the piano. The four of them gathered near the shoreline—Todd—tall, dark-haired, as handsome as the former-actor-turned-laid-off-network-executive he was, snuggling his then eight-year-old daughter, Sam, the two of them looking adorable in matching white-on-white linen suits. They stood next to Ellie in her one-of-a-kind Alexandre Vauthier wedding gown flown direct from the designer’s French atelier, the neckline falling off her bronze shoulder just so. It was the type of gown that should have rocked St. Paul’s Cathedral to the awe of five hundred guests—ornate, ruffled, sequined, hand-sewn-by-blind-Belgian-nuns-type couture. Instead, Ellie had worn her long blond hair down and

disheveled, looking like a goddess standing barefoot on that white sand beach, carrying baby Giggy in a matching lace sling. Their blended family was even more beautiful than a traditional one because you could read the hope and survival in Sam's mixed Chino-Anglo features, Todd's artfully unshaven chin, Giggy's quintessentially docile English baby face, and Ellie's defiant smile.

Now Todd was puffy in the face, red in the eye, sour in the disposition, less employed than he'd ever been, and possibly cheating on her; Sam, who'd always been her favorite, seemed to hate her guts; Giggy, who was ten years old, still couldn't read despite a quarter million dollars a year spent on private tutoring; six-year-old twins Elijah and Otis were surely causing their usual mayhem somewhere in the house; and Ellie's long-anticipated fortieth birthday party was teetering on disaster.

No matter, Ellie would get everything photoshopped to perfection later. Too bad there wasn't a Valencia filter to smooth out memories.

"Is Lord Fauntleroy coming?" Todd asked, using his favorite nickname for Giggy's biological dad.

"Of course Archer's coming," Ellie snapped. "You know that."

Ellie had invited everyone in her life to her fortieth birthday party in the same exact way that she'd invited everyone she knew—however barely—to her wedding ten years ago. She'd sent envelopes to the likes of Marc Jacobs, Karl Lagerfeld, and Anna Wintour. Privately, Ellie was a little embarrassed at her neediness, her graspy-ness, her *reach*.

But she couldn't help herself. She wanted more. She'd wanted desperately to be personal friends with Marc, Karl, and Anna,

and even if all three had returned the response cards with polite regrets (carefully preserved in her wedding memory box), she was glad she'd tried. She'd had the sense not to invite them to her birthday party, instead focusing on the nouveau riche LA circle they ran in—parent friends from the kids' private schools, old friends from the garment trade in New York and London, a few boldface names from Todd's past, and rich couples they'd met at American Express Black Card events.

Of course she'd invited her first husband, Archer de Florent. It was only right since Giggy—*Imogen*—spent two weeks with him in London every year. Archer was almost twice Ellie's age, and at seventy-eight still wore his crisp bespoke white shirts unbuttoned down to his navel (to show off his year-round Caribbean tan) and tucked into his too-tight jeans. He'd surely be bringing one of his post-pubescent-looking girlfriends tonight. Artists, actresses, dreamers, and gold diggers all.

She'd been one of those girls once, sitting cross-legged on his yacht in a gold string bikini, all of seventeen, Archer smiling wolfishly from the captain's chair. They'd met on the circuit in St. Tropez.

Except instead of just a sore ass and a smile, Ellie had won the mother lode, so to speak, by securing the de Florent fortune. Back then, Archer couldn't wait to pop Ellie's cherry, couldn't believe he was so lucky, that he was her first (or so she'd told him), and he'd proposed and promised this gorgeous thing anything she wanted. She'd asked if she could give him a child once they were married, and he'd agreed. But before they tied the knot, they broke up a couple of times, finally marrying when she was

twenty-two. She wanted a baby immediately, except the time was never quite right. Archer kept postponing it, and when she finally got pregnant, she was almost thirty and they were on the verge of divorce.

Ellie looked like she'd grown up in Connecticut hedge fund country and summered in Maine, with her thick flaxen hair (colored by the best, the same team that did Gwyneth's), a tiny, perfect nose (sculpted by the best, the same team that did actresses whose names can't be divulged), a deliberately crooked grin (flawed is more perfect than perfect because otherwise she'd look like a soap star—cheap), and golden tan, the kind of girl from whom American dreams were made. But in truth she was from a veritable trailer park, with a deadbeat dad and a scarred, world-weary mom in the withered branches of her family tree.

Not that Archer knew or cared about any of it, not when he'd married her, and not when they'd fucked in the penthouse suite of the Peninsula Hotel in Hong Kong to conceive Imogen. She'd forced his secretary to put it on his schedule and divert him from his meeting in Bahrain since Ellie was taking fertility drugs and ovulating. No matter that they were hardly speaking by then and hated each other's guts. He'd promised her a child and, boy, was he going to give her one.

Ellie had just finalized her divorce from Archer, and Giggy was four months old, when she met Todd, and for the first five years of her life, Todd was the only father Giggy ever knew. He'd wanted to give Giggy his last name even, and Ellie had considered it for a brief moment, but familial unity was no match for half the land in Norfolk, Beaumont Castle, and family history that went

back to the sixth Earl of Surrey and a Viceroy of India—Archer’s great-grandfathers, naturally. Imogen even had a title. Technically, she was Lady Imogen de Florent. Technically, Ellie had a title too, but she never used it; not even she would assume to reach that high. She wasn’t a tacky Real Housewife.

Besides, six years ago, she and Todd had finally gotten their own little miracle. Two, to be exact. As if on cue, the twins ran in with jelly hands, sticky, fighting as usual.

“Eli! Otis! Stop that!” she yelled as they ran around the dining table, leaving handprints on the tablecloth.

She was turning forty, her company was worth thirty million dollars, she was “happily married” (a stretch, but they weren’t getting divorced yet, so that was something), she had four gorgeous children (counting Sam, which she always did), and it was time to celebrate in this fabulous new house that she had bought fully furnished just two months ago.

It was going to be grand. Everyone who was everyone, everyone who mattered in her life, was going to be there tonight.

Her phone buzzed with yet another text. Assuming it was Nathaniel, her assistant, again, she started to type FUCK THE HYDRANGEAS GET ME SOME SUNFLOWERS when she saw the name on the screen.

Talk about a blast from the past.

From *before*.

Before she was Ellie de Florent-Stinson.

Before she was herself, really.

Happy birthday, girl.

The text came with a photo—taken twenty-four years ago. Could it really have been twenty-four years ago that she had been that young girl in that picture?

There she was, in all her glory. Her hair all over her face, her smile, wary instead of megawatt, her clothes, cheap and ill-fitting.

Another text: See you tonight.

A promise or a threat? Was she feeling butterflies or tasting bile? She looked at him in the photo, standing next to her, so handsome and so young.

It was her fortieth birthday. All the important people in her life would be there. Including *him*.

City of Girls
Elizabeth Gilbert

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CITY
OF
GIRLS



ELIZABETH GILBERT

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In the summer of 1940, when I was nineteen years old and an idiot, my parents sent me to live with my Aunt Peg, who owned a theater company in New York City.

I had recently been excused from Vassar College, on account of never having attended classes and thereby failing every single one of my freshman exams. I was not quite as dumb as my grades made me look, but apparently it really doesn't help if you don't study. Looking back on it now, I cannot fully recall what I'd been doing with my time during those many hours that I ought to have spent in class, but—knowing me— I suppose I was terribly preoccupied with my appearance. (I do remember that I was trying to master a “reverse roll” that year— a hairstyling technique that, while infinitely important to me and also quite challenging, was *not very Vassar*.)

I'd never found my place at Vassar, although there were places to be found there. All different types of girls and cliques existed at the school, but none of them stirred my curiosity, nor did I see myself reflected in any of them. There were political revolutionaries at Vassar that year wearing their serious black trousers and discussing their opinions on international foment, but I wasn't interested in international foment. (I'm still not. Although I did take notice of the black trousers, which I found intriguingly chic— but only if the pockets didn't bulge.) And there were girls at Vassar who were bold academic explorers, destined to become doctors and lawyers long before many women did that sort of thing. I should have been interested in them, but I wasn't. (I couldn't tell any of them apart, for one thing. They all wore the same shapeless wool skirts that looked as though they'd been constructed out of old sweaters, and that just made my spirits low.)

It's not like Vassar was *completely* devoid of glamour. There were some sentimental, doe-eyed medievalists who were quite pretty, and some artistic girls with long and self-important hair, and some highbred socialite types with profiles like Italian greyhounds— but I

didn't befriend any of them. Maybe it's because I sensed that everybody at this school was smarter than me. (This was not entirely youthful paranoia; I uphold to this day that everybody there *was* smarter than me.)

To be honest, I didn't understand what I was doing at college, aside from fulfilling a destiny whose purpose nobody had bothered explaining to me. From earliest childhood, I'd been told that I would attend Vassar, but nobody had told me why. What was it all *for*? What was I meant to get out of it, exactly? And why was I living in this cabbage little dormitory room with an earnest future social reformer?

I was so fed up with learning by that time, anyhow. I'd already studied for years at the Emma Willard School for Girls in Troy, New York, with its brilliant, all- female faculty of Seven Sisters graduates— and wasn't that enough? I'd been at boarding school since I was twelve years old, and maybe I felt that I had done my time. How many more books does a person need to read in order to prove that she can read a book? I already knew who Charlemagne was, so leave me alone, is how I saw it.

Also, not long into my doomed freshman year at Vassar, I had discovered a bar in Poughkeepsie that offered cheap beer and live jazz deep into the night. I'd figured out a way to sneak off campus to patronize this bar (my cunning escape plan involving an unlocked lavatory window and a hidden bicycle— believe me, I was the bane of the house warden), thereby making it difficult for me to absorb Latin conjugations first thing in the morning because I was usually hungover.

There were other obstacles, as well.

I had all those cigarettes to smoke, for instance.

In short: I was busy.

Therefore, out of a class of 362 bright young Vassar women, I ended up ranked at 361—a fact that caused my father to remark in horror, “Dear God, what was that *other* girl doing?” (Contracting polio as it turned out, the poor thing.) So Vassar sent me home—fair enough—and kindly requested that I not return.

My mother had no idea what to do with me. We didn’t have the closest relationship even under the best of circumstances. She was a keen horsewoman, and given that I was neither a horse nor fascinated by horses, we’d never had much to talk about. Now I’d embarrassed her so severely with my failure that she could scarcely stand the sight of me. In contrast to me, my mother had performed quite well at Vassar College, thank you very much. (Class of 1915. History and French.) Her legacy—as well as her generous yearly donations—had secured my admission to that hallowed institution, and now look at me. Whenever she passed me in the hallways of our house, she would nod at me like a career diplomat. Polite, but chilly.

My father didn’t know what to do with me, either, though he was busy running his hematite mine and didn’t overly concern himself with the problem of his daughter. I had disappointed him, true, but he had bigger worries. He was an industrialist and an isolationist, and the escalating war in Europe was spooking him about the future of his business. So I suppose he was distracted with all that.

As for my older brother, Walter, he was off doing great things at Princeton, and giving no thought to me, other than to disapprove of my irresponsible behavior. Walter had never done an irresponsible thing in his life. He’d been so respected by his peers back in boarding school that his nickname had been—and I am not making this up—the *Ambassador*. He was now studying engineering because he wanted to build infrastructure that would help people around the world. (Add it to my catalogue of sins that I, by contrast, was not quite sure I even knew what the word

“infrastructure” meant.) Although Walter and I were close in age— separated by a mere two years— we had not been playmates since we were quite little. My brother had put away his childish things when he was about nine years old, and among those childish things was me. I wasn’t part his life, and I knew it.

My own friends were moving forward with their lives, too. They were heading off to college, work, marriage, and adulthood— all subjects that I had no interest in or understanding of. So there was nobody around to care about me or entertain me. I was bored and listless. My boredom felt like hunger pains. I spent the first two weeks of June hitting a tennis ball against the side of our garage while whistling “Little Brown Jug” again and again, until finally my parents got sick of me and shipped me off to live with my aunt in the city, and honestly, who could blame them?

American Royals

Katharine McGee

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AMERICAN ROYALS

KATHARINE MCGEE

Random House  New York

Keep reading for a sneak peek. . . .

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PROLOGUE

You already know the story of the American Revolution, and the birth of the American monarchy.

You might know it from the picture books you read as a child. From your elementary school performances—when you longed to play the role of King George I or Queen Martha, and instead were cast as a cherry tree. You know it from songs and movies and history textbooks, from that summer you visited the capital and went on the official Washington Palace tour.

You've heard the story so many times that you could tell it yourself: how, after the Battle of Yorktown, Colonel Lewis Nicola fell to his knees before General George Washington and begged him on behalf of the entire nation to become America's first king.

Of course, the general said yes.

Historians love to debate whether, in another world, things might have gone differently. What if General Washington had refused to be king, and asked to be an elected representative instead? A prime minister—or perhaps he would have made up an entirely new name for that office, like *president*. Maybe, inspired by America's example, other nations—France and Russia and Prussia, Austria-Hungary and China and Greece—would eventually abolish their own monarchies, giving rise to a new democratic age.

But we all know that never happened. And you didn't come here for a made-up story. You came here for the story of what happens next. What America looks like two hundred and fifty years later, when the descendants of George I are still on the throne.

It is a story of soaring ballrooms and backstairs corridors. Of secrets and scandal, of love and heartbreak. It is the story of the most famous family in the world, who play out their family dramas on the greatest stage of all.

This is the story of the American royals.



BEATRICE

Present Day

Beatrice could trace her ancestry back to the tenth century.

It was really only through Queen Martha's side, though most people refrained from mentioning that. After all, King George I had been nothing but an upstart planter from Virginia until he married well and then fought even better. He fought so well that he helped win America's independence, and was rewarded by its people with a crown.

But through Martha, at least, Beatrice could trace her lineage for more than forty generations. Among her forebears were kings and queens and archdukes, scholars and soldiers, even a canonized saint. *We have much to learn by looking back*, her father always reminded her. *Never forget where you come from.*

It was hard to forget your ancestors when you carried their names with you as Beatrice did: Beatrice Georgina Fredericka Louise of the House of Washington, Princess Royal of America.

Beatrice's father, His Majesty King George IV, shot her a glance. She reflexively sat up straighter, to listen as the High Constable reviewed the plans for tomorrow's Queen's Ball. Her hands were clasped over her demure pencil skirt, her legs crossed at the ankle. Because as her etiquette teacher had drilled into her—by hitting her wrist with a ruler each time she slipped up—a lady never crossed her legs at the thigh.

And the rules were especially stringent for Beatrice because she was not only a princess: she was also the first woman who would ever inherit the American throne. The first woman who would be queen in her own right: not a queen consort, married to a king, but a true queen regnant.

If she'd been born twenty years earlier, the succession would have jumped over her and skipped to Jeff. But her grandfather had famously abolished that centuries-old law, dictating that in all subsequent generations, the throne would pass to the oldest child, not the oldest boy.

Beatrice let her gaze drift over the conference table before her. It was littered with papers and scattered cups of coffee that had long since gone cold. Today's was the last Cabinet session until January, which meant it had been filled with year-end reports and long spreadsheets of analysis.

The Cabinet meetings always took place here in the Star Chamber, named for the gilded stars painted on its blue walls, and the famous star-shaped oculus overhead. Winter sunlight poured through it to dapple invitingly over the table. Not that Beatrice would get to enjoy it. She rarely had time to go outside, except on the days she rose before dawn to join her father on his run through the capital, flanked by their security officers.

For a brief and uncharacteristic moment, she wondered what her siblings were doing right now, if they were back yet from their whirlwind trip through East Asia. Samantha and Jeff—twins, and three years younger than Beatrice—were a dangerous pair. They were lively and spontaneous, full of bad ideas, and with far too much power to act on them. Now, six months after they'd finished high school, it was clear that neither of them knew what to do with themselves—except celebrate the fact that they were eighteen and could legally drink.

No one ever expected anything of the twins. All the

expectation, in the family and really in the *world*, was focused like a white-hot spotlight on Beatrice.

At last the High Constable finished his report. The king gave a gracious nod and stood. “Thank you, Jacob. If there is no further business, that concludes today’s meeting.”

Everyone rose to their feet and began to shuffle out of the room, chatting about tomorrow’s ball or their holiday plans. They seemed to have temporarily set aside their political rivalries—the king kept his Cabinet evenly divided between the Federalists and the Democratic-Republicans—though Beatrice felt certain those rivalries would be back in full force come the new year.

Her personal security detail, Connor, glanced up from where he stood outside the door, next to the king’s protection officer. Both men were members of the Revere Guard, the elite corps of officers who devoted their lives to the service of the Crown.

“Beatrice, could you stay for a minute?” her dad asked.

Beatrice paused before following the other Cabinet members into the hallway. “Of course.”

Her father sat back down, and she followed suit. “Thank you again for helping with the nominations,” he told her. They both glanced at the paper before him, where a list of names was printed in alphabetical order.

Beatrice smiled. “I’m glad you accepted them.”

Tomorrow was the palace’s annual holiday party, the Queen’s Ball, so named because at the very first Christmas ball, Queen Martha had urged George I to ennoble dozens of Americans who’d aided the Revolution. The tradition had persisted ever since. Each year at the ball, the king knighted Americans for their service to the country, thereby making them lords or ladies. And for the first time, he had let Beatrice suggest the candidates for knighthood.

Before she could ask what he wanted, a tap sounded at

the door. The king gave an audible sigh of relief as Beatrice's mom swept into the room.

Queen Adelaide came from nobility on both sides of her family. Before her marriage to the king, she'd been set to inherit the Duchy of Canaveral *and* the Duchy of Savannah. The Double Duchess, people had called her.

Adelaide had grown up in Atlanta, and had never lost her ethereal Southern charm. Even now her gestures were touched with elegance: the tilt of her head as she smiled at her daughter, the turn of her wrist as she settled into the walnut chair to Beatrice's right. Caramel highlights gleamed in her rich brown hair, which she curled each morning with hot rollers and wore encircled by a headband.

The way they were sitting—a parent to either side of Beatrice, boxing her in—gave her the distinct sense that she was being ambushed.

“Hey, Mom,” she said in a slightly puzzled tone. The queen wasn't usually part of their political discussions.

“Beatrice, your mother and I were hoping to discuss your future,” the king began.

The princess blinked, disconcerted. She was always thinking about the future.

“On a more personal level,” her mom clarified. “We were wondering if there was anyone . . . special in your life right now.”

Beatrice startled. She'd expected this talk sooner or later, had done her best to mentally prepare herself for it. She just hadn't assumed it would be quite so *soon*.

“No, there isn't,” she assured them. Her parents nodded distractedly; they both knew she wasn't dating anyone. The entire *country* knew it.

The king cleared his throat. “Your mother and I were hoping that you might start searching for a partner. For that person you'll spend your life with.”

His words seemed to echo, amplified, around the Star Chamber.

Beatrice had almost no romantic experience to speak of—not that the various foreign princes near her age hadn't tried. The only one to make it to a second date had been Prince Nikolaos of Greece. His parents had urged him to do an exchange program at Harvard one semester, clearly hoping that he and the American princess would fall madly in love. Beatrice went out with him for a while to please their families, but nothing had come of it—even though, as a younger son of a royal family, Nikolaos was one of the few men actually *eligible* to go out with Beatrice. The future monarch could only marry someone of noble or aristocratic blood.

Beatrice had always known that she couldn't date the wrong person—couldn't even kiss the wrong person, the way everyone else at college seemed to. After all, no one wanted to see their future monarch walk-of-shaming home from a college party.

No, it was much safer if the heir to the throne had no sexual past for the press to rake through: no baggage from past boyfriends, no exes who might sell intimate secrets in a tell-all memoir. There could be no ups and downs in Beatrice's relationships. Once she publicly dated someone, that was it: they would have to be happy, and stable, and committed.

It had been enough to make her steer clear of dating almost entirely.

For years the press had applauded Beatrice for being careful with her reputation. But ever since she'd turned twenty-one in June, she'd noticed a shift in the way they discussed her love life. Instead of dedicated and virtuous, the reporters had begun to call her lonely and pitiable—or worse, frigid. If she never dated anyone, they complained, how was she supposed to get married, and start the all-important business of providing the *next* heir to the throne?

“Don’t you think I’m a little young to worry about this?” Beatrice asked, relieved at how calm she sounded. But then, she had long ago been trained to keep her emotions hidden from public display.

“Your father and I were your age when we got married. And I was pregnant with you the following year,” the queen reminded her. A truly terrifying thought.

“That was twenty years ago!” Beatrice protested. “No one expects me to—I mean—things are different now.”

“We’re not saying you should run to the altar tomorrow. All we’re asking is that you start to think about it. This won’t be an easy decision, and we want to help.”

“Help?”

“There are several young men whom we’d love for you to meet. We’ve invited them all to the ball tomorrow night.” The queen unclasped her pebbled-leather handbag and pulled out a folder, colored plastic tabs peeking from its edge. She handed it to her daughter.

Each tab was labeled with a name. Lord José de Moraga, future Duke of Orange. Lord Matthew Albright, future Duke of the Ozarks. Lord Theodore Eaton, future Duke of Boston.

“You’re trying to *set me up*?”

“We’re just giving you some options. Introducing you to young men who might be a good fit.”

Beatrice flipped numbly through the pages. They were filled with information: family trees, photos, high school transcripts, even the guys’ heights and weights.

“Did you use your security clearance to get all this?”

“What? No.” The king looked shocked at the suggestion that he would abuse his privileges with the NSA. “The young men and their families all volunteered this information. They know what they’re signing on for.”

“So you’ve already talked to them,” Beatrice said woodenly.

“And tomorrow night at the Queen’s Ball you want me to interview these . . . potential *husbands*?”

Her mother’s brows shot up in protest. “*Interview* makes it sound so impersonal! All we’re asking is that you have a conversation with them, get to know them a little. Who knows? One of them might surprise you.”

“Maybe it is like an interview,” the king admitted. “Beatrice, when you do choose someone, he won’t just be your husband. He will also be America’s first king consort. And being married to the reigning monarch is a full-time job.”

“A job that never stops,” the queen chimed in.

Through the window, down in the Marble Courtyard, Beatrice heard a burst of laughter and gossip, and a single voice struggling valiantly to rise above the din. Probably a high school tour going past, on the last day before holiday break. These teenagers weren’t that much younger than she was, yet Beatrice felt irrevocably distant from them.

She used her thumb to pull back the pages of the folder and let them fan back down. Only a dozen young men were included.

“This folder is pretty thin,” she said softly.

Of course, Beatrice had always known that she would be fishing from a tiny pond, that her romantic options were incredibly narrow. It wasn’t as bad as it had been a hundred years ago, when the marriage of the king was a matter of public policy rather than a matter of the heart. At least she wouldn’t have to get married to seal a political treaty.

But it still seemed a lot to hope, that she might find someone on this list whom she could fall in love with.

“Your father and I were very thorough. We combed through all the sons and grandsons of the nobility before we compiled this list,” her mother said gently.

The king nodded. “There are some good options here,

Beatrice. Everyone in this folder is smart, and thoughtful, and from a good family—the type of men who will support you, without letting their egos get in the way.”

From a good family. Beatrice knew precisely what that meant. They were the sons and grandsons of high-ranking American noblemen, if only because the foreign princes around her age—Nikolaos, or Charles of Schleswig-Holstein, or the Grand Duke Pieter—had all already struck out.

Beatrice glanced back and forth between her parents. “What if my future husband isn’t on this list? What if I don’t want to marry *any* of them?”

“You haven’t even met them yet,” her father cut in. “Besides, your mother and I were set up by our parents, and look how that turned out.” He met the queen’s eyes with a fond smile.

Beatrice nodded, a bit reassured. She knew that her dad had picked her mom just like this, from a short list of pre-approved options. They had met only a dozen times before their wedding day. And their arranged marriage had ended up blossoming into a genuine love match.

She tried to consider the possibility that her parents were right: that she could fall in love with one of the young men listed in this terrifyingly slim folder.

It didn’t seem likely.

She hadn’t yet met these noblemen, but she could already guess what they were like: the same type of spoiled, self-absorbed young men who’d been circling her for years. The type of guys she’d been carefully turning down at Harvard, each time they asked her to a final club party or fraternity date night. The type of guys who looked at her and saw not a person, but a crown.

Sometimes, Beatrice thought traitorously, that was how her parents saw her too.

Her father braced his palms on the conference table.

Against the tanned skin of his hands glinted a pair of rings: the simple gold of his wedding band and, next to it, the heavy signet ring marked with the Great Seal of America. His two marriages, to the queen and to his country.

“Our hope for you has always been that you might find someone you love, who can also handle the requirements that come with this life,” he told her. “Someone who is the right fit for you *and* America.”

Beatrice heard the unspoken subtext: that if she couldn’t find someone who checked both boxes, then America needed to come first. It was more important that she marry someone who could do this job, and do it well, than that she follow her heart.

And truthfully, Beatrice had given up on her heart a long time ago. Her life didn’t belong to her, her choices were never fully her own—she had known this since she was a child.

Her grandfather King Edward III had said as much to her on his deathbed. The memory would be forever etched into her memory: the sterile smell of the hospital, the yellow fluorescent lighting, the peremptory way her grandfather had dismissed everyone else from the room. “I need to say a few things to Beatrice,” he’d declared, in that frightening growl he used just for her.

The dying king had taken Beatrice’s small hands in his frail ones. “Long ago, monarchies existed so that the people could serve the monarch. Now the monarch must serve the people. Remember that it is an honor and a privilege to be a Washington and devote your life to this nation.”

Beatrice gave a solemn nod. She knew it was her duty to put the people first; everyone had been telling her that since she was born. The words *In service to God and country* had literally been painted on the walls of her nursery.

“From this point onward you are two people at once: Beatrice the girl, and Beatrice, heir to the Crown. When they

want different things,” her grandfather said gravely, “the Crown must win. Always. Swear it to me.” His fingers closed around hers with a surprising amount of strength.

“I swear,” Beatrice had whispered. She didn’t remember consciously choosing to say those words; as if some greater force, perhaps the spirit of America itself, had taken temporary hold of her and snatched them from her chest.

Beatrice lived by that sacred oath. She had always known that this decision was looming in her future. But the suddenness of it all—the fact that her parents expected her to start picking a *husband* tomorrow, and from such an abbreviated list—made her breath catch.

“You know that this life isn’t an easy one,” the king said gently. “That it often looks so different from the outside than it really is on the inside. Beatrice, it’s crucial that you find the right partner to share it with. Someone to help you through the challenges and share in the successes. Your mother and I are a team. I couldn’t have done any of it without her.”

Beatrice swallowed against a tightness in her throat. Well, if she needed to get married for the country’s sake, she might as well try to pick one of her parents’ choices.

“Should we look through the candidates before I meet them tomorrow?” she said at last, and opened the folder to its first page.

2

NINA

Nina Gonzalez clattered up the stairs at the back of the lecture hall, headed toward her usual seat in the mezzanine. Below her stretched hundreds of red auditorium chairs, each affixed with a wooden desk. Almost every seat was occupied. This was Intro to World History, a required class for all freshmen at King's College: King Edward I had decreed as much when he founded the university back in 1828.

She rolled up the sleeves of her flannel shirt, and a tattoo flashed on her wrist, its angular lines inscribed on her burnished sienna skin. It was the Chinese character for *friendship*. Samantha had insisted that they get the tattoo together, to commemorate their eighteenth birthdays. Of course, Sam couldn't very well be seen with a tattoo, so hers was somewhere decidedly more private.

"You're coming tonight, right?" Nina's friend Rachel Greenbaum leaned over from the next chair.

"Tonight?" Nina reached up to tuck her dark hair behind one ear. A cute boy at the end of the row was glancing her way, but she ignored him. He looked too much like the one she was still trying to get over.

"We're meeting in the common room to watch the coverage of the Queen's Ball. I made cherry tarts using the official recipe, the one from the Washington cookbook. I even

bought cherries from the palace gift shop, to make it authentic,” Rachel said eagerly.

“That sounds delicious.” Those cherry tarts were famous worldwide: the palace had served them at every garden party or reception for generations. Nina wondered what Rachel would say if she found out how much the Washingtons secretly hated those tarts.

Honestly, it would have been more authentic if she’d cooked barbecue instead. Or breakfast tacos. Both of which the royal family ate with shocking frequency.

“So you’re coming, right?” Rachel pressed.

Nina did her best to look regretful. “I can’t. I actually have a shift tonight.” She worked at the university library shelving books, as part of the work-study program that funded her scholarship. But even if she hadn’t been busy, Nina had no desire to watch the coverage of the Queen’s Ball. She’d attended that ball several years in a row, and it was pretty much the same every time.

“I didn’t know the library was *open* on Friday nights.”

“Maybe you should come with me. Some of the seniors still have finals; you might meet an older guy,” Nina teased.

“Only you would daydream about a library meet-cute.” Rachel shook her head, then let out a wistful sigh. “I wonder what Princess Beatrice will wear tonight. Do you remember the gown she wore last year, with the illusion neckline? It was *so* elegant.”

Nina didn’t want to talk about the royal family, especially not with Rachel, who was a little too obsessed with them. She’d once told Nina that she’d named her pet goldfish Jefferson—all ten of them in succession. But a deep-seated loyalty to Samantha made Nina speak up. “What about Samantha? She always looks beautiful too.”

Rachel made a vague noise of disagreement, ignoring the question. It was an all-too-typical reaction. The nation adored

Beatrice, their future sovereign—or at least most people adored her, except the sexist, reactionary groups that still protested the Act of Succession to the Crown. Those people hated Beatrice, simply for having the temerity to be a woman who would inherit a throne that had always belonged to men. They were a minority, but they were still vicious and vocal, always trolling online photos of Beatrice, booing her at political rallies.

But if most of the nation loved Beatrice, they positively swooned over Jefferson, with what sometimes felt like a single collective sigh. He was the only boy, and the world seemed willing to forgive him anything, even if Nina wasn't.

As for Samantha . . . at best people were entertained by her. At worst, which was relatively often, they actively disapproved of her. The problem was that they didn't *know* Sam. Not the way Nina did.

She was saved from answering by Professor Urquhart, who started up to the podium with ponderous steps. There was a flurry of activity as all seven hundred students broke off their murmured conversations and arranged their laptops before them. Nina—who was probably the last person still taking notes by hand, in a spiral notebook—poised her pencil on a fresh page and glanced up expectantly. Dust motes hung suspended in the bars of sunlight that sliced through the windows.

“As we've covered all semester, political alliances through the turn of the century were typically bilateral and easily broken—which is why so many of them were sealed through marriage,” Professor Urquhart began. “Things changed with the formation of the League of Kings: a treaty among multiple nations, meant to assure collective security and peace. The League was founded in 1895 at the Concord of Paris, hosted by—”

Louis, Nina silently finished. That was the easiest part of

French history: their kings were consistently named Louis, all the way up to the current Louis XXIII. Honestly, the French were even worse about *Louis* than the Washingtons were about *George*.

She copied the professor's words into her spiral notebook, wishing that she could stop thinking about the Washingtons. College was supposed to be her fresh start, a chance to figure out who she really was, free from the influence of the royal family.

Nina had been Princess Samantha's best friend since they were children. They had met twelve years ago, when Nina's mom, Isabella, interviewed at the palace. The former king—Edward III, Samantha's grandfather—had just passed away, and the new king needed a chamberlain. Isabella had been working in the Chamber of Commerce, and somehow, miraculously, her boss recommended her to His Majesty. There was no “applying” to jobs in the palace. The palace made a list of candidates, and if you were one of the lucky few, *they* reached out to *you*.

The afternoon of her mom's interview, Nina's usual babysitter canceled at the last minute. Isabella had no choice but to bring Nina with her. “Stay right here,” she admonished, leading her daughter to a bench in the downstairs corridor.

Nina had found it surprising that her mom was interviewing in the actual *palace*, but as she would later learn, Washington Palace wasn't just the royal family's home in the capital. It was also the administrative center of the Crown. By far the majority of the palace's six hundred rooms were offices or public spaces. The private apartments on the second floor were all marked by oval-shaped door handles, rather than the round ones downstairs.

Nina tucked her feet beneath her and quietly opened the book she'd brought.

“What are you reading?”

A face topped by a mountain of chestnut hair peered around the corner. Nina instantly recognized Princess Samantha. Though she didn't look much like a princess in her zebra-print leggings and sequined dress. Her fingernails were painted in a rainbow, each one a different primary color.

"Um . . ." Nina hid the cover in her lap. The book was about a princess, albeit a fantasy one, but it still felt strange to confess that to a *real* princess.

"My little brother and I are reading a dragon series right now," Samantha declared, and tipped her head to one side. "Have you seen him? I can't find him."

Nina shook her head. "I thought you were twins," she couldn't resist saying.

"Yes, but I'm four minutes older, which makes Jeff my little brother," Samantha replied with irrefutable logic. "Want to help me look for him?"

The princess was a storm of kinetic energy, skipping down the halls, constantly opening doors or peering behind furniture in search of her twin. The entire time she kept up a steady stream of chatter, her own greatest-hits tour of the palace.

"This room is haunted by the ghost of Queen Thérèse. I know it's her because the ghost speaks French," she declared ominously, pointing at the shuttered downstairs parlor. Or "I used to roller-skate down these halls, till my dad caught me and said I can't. Beatrice did it too, but it never matters what Beatrice does." Samantha didn't sound resentful, just pensive. "She's going to be queen someday."

"And what are you going to be?" Nina asked, curious.

Samantha grinned. "Everything else."

She led Nina from one unbelievable place to another, through storerooms of pressed linen napkins and kitchens that soared larger than ballrooms, where the chef gave them sugar cookies out of a painted blue jar. The princess bit into

her cookie, but Nina tucked hers into her pocket. It was too pretty to eat.

As they looped back toward the bench, Nina was startled to see her mom walking down the hallway, chatting easily with the king. Their eyes lit on Nina, and she instinctively froze.

The king smiled, a genial, boyish smile that made his eyes twinkle. “And who have we here?”

Nina had never met a king before, yet some unbidden instinct—perhaps all the times she’d seen him on television—prompted her to bob into a curtsy.

“This is my daughter, Nina,” Isabella murmured.

Samantha trotted over to her father and tugged at his hand. “Dad, can Nina come over again soon?” she pleaded.

The king turned his warm eyes on Nina’s mom. “Samantha is right. I hope you’ll bring Nina here in the afternoons. After all, it’s not like we have a short workday.”

Isabella blinked. “Your Majesty?”

“The girls clearly get along, and I know your wife has a busy schedule, too. Why should Nina stay home with a babysitter when she could be here?”

Nina was too young to understand her mom’s hesitation. “Please, Mom?” she’d chimed in, brimming with eagerness. Isabella had relented with a sigh.

And just like that, Nina was interwoven into the lives of the royal twins.

They became an instant threesome: the prince, the princess, and the chamberlain’s daughter. Back then Nina hadn’t even known to feel self-conscious about the differences between her life and Samantha’s. For even though they were twins, and *royalty*, Jeff and Sam never made Nina feel like an outsider. If anything, they were all equally excluded from the glamorous and inaccessible world of the adults—even from Beatrice, who at age ten was already enrolled in private tutoring on top of her middle school courses.

Sam and Jeff were always the instigators of their plans, with Nina trying and failing to keep them in line. They would escape the twins' nanny and set out on some escapade: to swim in the heated indoor pool, or to find the rumored safe rooms and bomb shelters that were supposedly hidden throughout the palace. One time Samantha convinced them to hide beneath a tablecloth and eavesdrop on a private meeting between the king and the Austrian ambassador. They were caught after just two minutes, when Jeff tugged on the tablecloth and knocked over a pitcher of water, but by then Samantha had already squirted honey into the ambassador's shoe. "If you don't want honey in your shoes, don't kick them off under the table," she'd said later, her eyes gleaming with mischief.

The fact that Samantha and Nina's friendship had survived all these years was a testament to the princess's determination. She refused to let them drift apart, even though they went to different schools, even after Nina's mom left her role as chamberlain and was named Minister of the Treasury. Samantha just kept on inviting Nina to the palace for sleepovers, or to the Washingtons' vacation homes for a holiday weekend, or to attend state events as her plus-one.

Nina's moms had mixed feelings about their daughter's friendship with the princess.

Isabella and Julie had met years ago in grad school. By now they were one of Washington's power couples: Isabella working as Minister of the Treasury, Julie the founder of a successful e-commerce business. They didn't argue very often, but Nina's complicated relationship with the Washingtons was something they never managed to agree on.

"We can't let Nina go on that trip," Isabella had protested, after Samantha invited Nina to the royal family's beach house. "I don't want her spending too much time with them, especially when we aren't around."

Nina's ears perked up at her parents' voices, which drifted up through the building's old-fashioned heating pipes. She was in her bedroom on the third floor, beneath the attic. She hadn't meant to eavesdrop . . . but she'd also never confessed how easily she could hear them when they spoke in the sitting room directly below.

"Why not?" Julie had replied, her voice oddly distorted by the old metal pipes.

"Because I worry about her! The world that the Washingtons inhabit, with all its private planes and court galas and protocol—that isn't reality. And no matter how often they invite her or how much Princess Samantha likes her, Nina will never really be one of them." Isabella sighed. "I don't want her feeling like a poor relation from some Jane Austen novel."

Nina shifted closer on her mattress to catch the response.

"The princess has been a good friend to Nina," Julie protested. "And you should have a little more faith in the way we've raised our daughter. If anything, I think Nina will be a positive influence on Samantha, by reminding her what exists outside those palace gates. The princess probably *needs* a normal friend."

By the time they were in high school, Nina was used to her best friend's quirky plans and contagious excitement. *Let's take Albert out!* Sam would text, naming the lemon-yellow Jeep she'd begged her parents to give her on her sixteenth birthday. She had the car, but she kept failing the parallel-parking part of her driver's test and still didn't have a license. Which meant that Nina ended up driving that obnoxiously yellow Jeep all through the capital, with Samantha sitting cross-legged in the passenger seat, begging her to swing through McDonald's. After a while Nina didn't even worry about the protection officer glowering at them from the back.

Sam made it far too easy for Nina to forget the myriad differences between them. And Nina loved her, without strings

or conditions, the way she would have loved a sister if she'd had one. It was just that her sister happened to be the princess of America.

But their relationship had subtly shifted over the past six months. Nina had never told Sam what happened the night of her graduation—and the longer she kept it a secret, the greater the distance it seemed to wedge between them. Then Sam and Jeff went off on their whirlwind post-graduation trip, and Nina was starting her first year of college, and maybe it was all for the best anyway. This was Nina's chance to settle into a more normal life, one without the private planes and court galas and protocol that had so worried Isabella. She could go back to being her ordinary, real-world self.

Nina hadn't told anyone at King's College that Samantha was her best friend. They would probably assume she was a liar—or if they did believe her, they might try to use her for her connections. Nina didn't know which outcome would be worse.

Professor Urquhart clicked off the microphone, marking the conclusion of the lecture. Everyone stood in a shuffle of closing laptops and suppressed gossip. Nina scribbled a few final notes in her spiral before tossing it into her shoulder bag, then followed Rachel down the stairs and out into the courtyard.

A few other girls from their hallway joined them, talking in excited tones about the Queen's Ball viewing party. They started toward the student center, where everyone usually grabbed lunch after class, but Nina's steps lingered.

A movement near the street had grabbed her attention. A black town car was idling at the curb, purring softly. Propped in the car window was a piece of white computer paper with Nina's name scrawled on it.

She would recognize that handwriting anywhere.

"Nina? Are you coming?" Rachel called out.

"Sorry, I have a meeting with my advisor," Nina fibbed. She waited a few more moments before racing across the lawn toward the car.

In the backseat was Princess Samantha, wearing velour sweatpants and a white T-shirt through which Nina could see her pink bra. Nina hurried to join her, pulling the door shut before anyone could see.

"*Nina!* I missed you!" Sam threw her arms around her friend in one of her typically effusive hugs.

"I missed you, too," Nina murmured into her friend's shoulder. A million questions burned on her lips.

Finally Samantha broke away, leaning forward to address the driver. "You can just circle campus for a while," she told him. Typical Sam, wanting to be in constant motion even if she wasn't going anywhere.

"Sam—what are you doing here? Shouldn't you be getting ready for tonight?"

Sam lowered her voice conspiratorially. "I'm kidnapping you and dragging you to the Queen's Ball as my plus-one!"

Nina shook her head. "Sorry, I have to work tonight."

"But your parents will be there—I'm sure they'd love to see you!" Sam let out a breath. "Please, Nina? I could really use some backup right now, with my mom and dad."

"Didn't you just get home?" What could they already be angry about?

"The last morning in Thailand, Jeff and I ran away from our protection officers," Sam admitted, looking out the window. They were driving up College Street toward the soaring Gothic architecture of Dandridge Library.

"You ditched your bodyguards? How?"

"We ran away from them," Samantha repeated, unable to suppress her smile. "Literally. Jeff and I turned and sprinted into oncoming traffic, weaving between the cars, then hitched

a ride to an ATV rental place. We rode four-wheelers through the jungle. It was incredible.”

“That seems risky,” Nina pointed out, and Sam laughed.

“You sound *just* like my parents! See, this is why I need you. I was hoping that if you came with me tonight . . .”

“I could keep you in line?” Nina finished for her. As if she’d ever been able to control the princess. No power on earth could keep Samantha from doing something once she’d set her mind to it.

“You know you’re the good one!”

“I’m only ‘the good one’ in comparison to you,” Nina countered. “That isn’t saying much.”

“You should be grateful I set the bar so low,” Sam teased. “Look, we can leave the reception early—grab some home-made cookie dough from the kitchens, stay up late watching bad reality TV. It’s been ages since we had a slumber party! Please,” she said again. “I’ve really missed you.”

It was hard to ignore that kind of plea from your best friend. “I guess . . . I could probably get Jodi to trade shifts with me,” Nina conceded, after a beat of hesitation so slight that Samantha probably hadn’t even noticed it.

“Thank you!” Sam gave a squeal of excitement. “By the way, I brought you something from Bangkok.” She dug through her bag, eventually emerging with a packet of pretzel M&M’s. The bright blue bag was covered in the gorgeous loops and curlicues of Thai script.

“You remembered.” M&M’s were Nina’s favorite candy. Sam always brought a bag of them home from her foreign trips—she’d read somewhere that the formula was tweaked in each country, and decided that she and Nina would have to taste-test all of them.

“So? How are they?” Sam asked as Nina popped one of the chocolate candies into her mouth.

“Delicious.” It was actually a little stale, but that wasn’t surprising given how many miles it had traveled, smashed into the side pocket of Samantha’s purse.

They turned a corner and the palace swam into view—far too soon for Nina’s liking, but after all, King’s College was only a couple of miles away. Virginia pines stretched tall and arrogant on either side of the street, which was lined with bureaucratic offices and thronged with people. The palace glowed a blazing white against the blue enamel of the sky. Its reflection danced in the waters of the Potomac, so that there seemed to be two palaces: one substantial, one watery and dreamlike.

Tourists clung to the palace’s iron gates, where a row of guards stood at attention, their hands raised in a salute. Above the circle drive Nina saw the fluttering edge of the Royal Standard, the flag indicating that the monarch was officially in residence.

She took a breath, steeling herself. She hadn’t wanted to come back to the palace and risk seeing *him*. She still hated him for what happened the night of the graduation party.

But more than that, Nina hated the small part of herself that secretly longed to see him, even after everything he had done.

The Secrets We Kept
Lara Prescott

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The Secrets We Kept



LARA PRESCOTT



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I want to be with those
who know secret things
or else alone.

—RAINER MARIA RILKE

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PROLOGUE



THE TYPISTS

We typed a hundred words per minute and never missed a syllable. Our identical desks were each equipped with a mint-shelled Royal Quiet Deluxe typewriter, a black Western Electric rotary phone, and a stack of yellow steno pads. Our fingers flew across the keys. Our clacking was constant. We'd pause only to answer the phone or to take a drag of a cigarette; some of us managed to master both without missing a beat.

The men would arrive around ten. One by one, they'd pull us into their offices. We'd sit in small chairs pushed into the corners while they'd sit behind their large mahogany desks or pace the carpet while speaking to the ceiling. We'd listen. We'd record. We were their audience of one for their memos, reports, write-ups, lunch orders. Sometimes they'd forget we were there and we'd learn much more: who was trying to box out whom, who was making a power play, who was having an affair, who was in and who was out.

Sometimes they'd refer to us not by name but by hair color or body type: Blondie, Red, Tits. We had our secret names for them, too: Grabber, Coffee Breath, Teeth.

They would call us girls, but we were not.

We came to the Agency by way of Radcliffe, Vassar, Smith. We

were the first daughters of our families to earn degrees. Some of us spoke Mandarin. Some could fly planes. Some of us could handle a Colt 1873 better than John Wayne. But all we were asked when interviewed was “Can you type?”

It’s been said that the typewriter was built for women—that to truly make the keys sing requires the feminine touch, that our narrow fingers are suited for the device, that while men lay claim to cars and bombs and rockets, the typewriter is a machine of our own.

Well, we don’t know about all that. But what we will say is that as we typed, our fingers became extensions of our brains, with no delay between the words coming out of their mouths—words they told us not to remember—and our keys slapping ink onto paper. And when you think about it like that, about the mechanics of it all, it’s almost poetic. Almost.

But did we aspire to tension headaches and sore wrists and bad posture? Is it what we dreamed of in high school, when studying twice as hard as the boys? Was clerical work what we had in mind when opening the fat manila envelopes containing our college acceptance letters? Or where we thought we’d be headed as we sat in those white wooden chairs on the fifty-yard line, capped and gowned, receiving the rolled parchments that promised we were qualified to do so much more?

Most of us viewed the job in the typing pool as temporary. We wouldn’t admit it aloud—not even to each other—but many of us believed it would be a first rung toward achieving what the men got right out of college: positions as officers; our own offices with lamps that gave off a flattering light, plush rugs, wooden desks; our own typists taking down *our* dictation. We thought of it as a beginning, not an end, despite what we’d been told all our lives.

Other women came to the Agency not to start their careers but to round them out. Leftovers from the OSS, where they’d been legends during the war, they’d become relics relegated to the typing pool or the records department or some desk in some corner with nothing to do.

There was Betty. During the war, she ran black ops, striking blows at opposition morale by planting newspaper articles and dropping propaganda flyers from airplanes. We'd heard she once provided dynamite to a man who blew up a resource train as it passed over a bridge somewhere in Burma. We could never be sure what was true and what wasn't; those old OSS records had a way of disappearing. But what we did know was that at the Agency, Betty sat at a desk along with the rest of us, the Ivy League men who were her peers during the war having become her bosses.

We think of Virginia, sitting at a similar desk—her thick yellow cardigan wrapped around her shoulders no matter the season, a pencil stuck in the bun atop her head. We think of her one fuzzy blue slipper underneath her desk—no need for the other, her left leg amputated after a childhood hunting accident. She'd named her prosthetic leg Cuthbert, and if she had too many drinks, she'd take it off and hand it to you. Virginia rarely spoke of her time in the OSS, and if you hadn't heard the secondhand stories about her spy days you'd think she was just another aging government gal. But we'd heard the stories. Like the time she disguised herself as a milkmaid and led a herd of cows and two French Resistance fighters to the border. How the Gestapo had called her one of the most dangerous of the allied spies—Cuthbert and all. Sometimes Virginia would pass us in the hall, or we'd share an elevator with her, or we'd see her waiting for the number sixteen bus at the corner of E and Twenty-First. We'd want to stop and ask her about her days fighting the Nazis—about whether she still thought of those days while sitting at that desk waiting for the next war, or for someone to tell her to go home.

They'd tried to push the OSS gals out for years—they had no use for them in their new cold war. Those same fingers that once pulled triggers had become better suited for the typewriter, it seemed.

But who were we to complain? It was a good job, and we were lucky to have it. And it was certainly more exciting than most government gigs. Department of Agriculture? Interior? Could you imagine?

The Soviet Russia Division, or SR, became our home away from

home. And just as the Agency was known as a boys' club, we formed our own group. We began thinking of ourselves as the Pool, and we were stronger for it.

Plus, the commute wasn't bad. We'd take buses or streetcars in bad weather and walk on nice days. Most of us lived in the neighborhoods bordering downtown: Georgetown, Dupont, Cleveland Park, Cathedral Heights. We lived alone in walk-up studios so small one could practically lie down and touch one wall with her head and the other with her toes. We lived in the last remaining boarding houses on Mass. Avenue, with lines of bunk beds and ten-thirty curfews. We often had roommates—other government gals with names like Agnes or Peg who were always leaving their pink foam curlers in the sink or peanut butter stuck to the back of the butter knife or used sanitary napkins improperly wrapped in the small wastebasket next to the sink.

Only Linda Murphy was married back then, and only just married. The marrieds never stayed long. Some stuck it out until they got pregnant, but usually as soon as an engagement ring was slipped on, they'd plan their departure. We'd eat Safeway sheet cake in the break room to see them off. The men would come in for a slice and say they were awfully sad to see them go; but we'd catch that glimmer in their eye as they thought about whichever newer, younger girl might take their place. We'd promise to keep in touch, but after the wedding and the baby, they'd settle down in the farthest corners of the District—places one would have to take a taxi or two buses to reach, like Bethesda or Fairfax or Alexandria. Maybe we'd make the journey out there for the baby's first birthday, but anything after that was unlikely.

Most of us were single, putting our career first, a choice we'd repeatedly have to tell our parents was not a political statement. Sure, they were proud when we graduated from college, but with each passing year spent making careers instead of babies, they grew increasingly confused about our state of husbandlessness and our rather odd decision to live in a city built on a swamp.

And sure, in summer, Washington's humidity was thick as a wet blanket, the mosquitoes tiger-striped and fierce. In the morning, our curls, done up the night before, would deflate as soon as we'd step outside. And the streetcars and buses felt like saunas but smelled like rotten sponges. Apart from a cold shower, there was never a moment when one felt less than sweaty and disheveled.

Winter didn't offer much reprieve. We'd bundle up and rush from our bus stop with our head down to avoid the winds that blew off the icy Potomac.

But in the fall, the city came alive. The trees along Connecticut Avenue looked like falling orange and red fireworks. And the temperature was lovely, no need to worry about our blouses being soaked through at the armpits. The hot dog vendors would serve fire-roasted chestnuts in small paper bags—the perfect amount for an evening walk home.

And each spring brought cherry blossoms and busloads of tourists who would walk the monuments and, not heeding the many signs, pluck the pink-and-white flowers and tuck them behind an ear or into a suit pocket.

Fall and spring in the District were times to linger, and in those moments we'd stop and sit on a bench or take a detour around the Reflecting Pool. Sure, inside the Agency's E Street complex the fluorescent lights cast everything in a harsh glow, exaggerating the shine on our forehead and the pores on our nose. But when we'd leave for the day and the cool air would hit our bare arms, when we'd choose to take the long walk home through the Mall, it was in those moments that the city on a swamp became a postcard.

But we also remember the sore fingers and the aching wrists and the endless memos and reports and dictations. We typed so much, some of us even dreamed of typing. Even years later, men we shared our beds with would remark that our fingers would sometimes twitch in our sleep. We remember looking at the clock every five minutes on Friday afternoons. We remember the paper cuts, the scratchy toilet paper, the way the lobby's hardwood floors smelled of Murphy Oil

Soap on Monday mornings and how our heels would skid across them for days after they were waxed.

We remember the one strip of windows lining the far end of SR—how they were too high to see out of, how all we could see anyway was the gray State Department building across the street, which looked exactly like our gray building. We'd speculate about their typing pool. What did they look like? What were their lives like? Did they ever look out their windows at our gray building and wonder about us?

At the time, those days felt so long and specific; but thinking back, they all blend. We can't tell you whether the Christmas party when Walter Anderson spilled red wine all over the front of his shirt and passed out at reception with a note pinned to his lapel that read DO NOT RESUSCITATE happened in '51 or '55. Nor do we remember if Holly Falcon was fired because she let a visiting officer take nude photos of her in the second-floor conference room, or if she was promoted because of those very photos and fired shortly after for some other reason.

But there are other things we do remember.

If you were to come to Headquarters and see a woman in a smart green tweed suit following a man into his office or a woman wearing red heels and a matching angora sweater at reception, you might've assumed these women were typists or secretaries; and you would've been right. But you would have also been wrong. *Secretary*: a person entrusted with a secret. From the Latin *secretus*, *secretum*. We all typed, but some of us did more. We spoke no word of the work we did after we covered our typewriters each day. Unlike some of the men, we could keep our secrets.

The Nobody People

Bob Proehl

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PROLOGUE



THE INCIDENT AT POWDER BASIN

*in the years before, when hateful men warned
of the coming,
crushing aluminum cans in their hands while
their
friends threw darts, or in rowboats tying flies,
they
spoke only of darkness.*

—EVE EWING, “Arrival Day”

When reporters from the *Gillette News-Record* asked the survivors of the Powder Basin mine collapse how they survived, all twenty-three gave variations on the same answer: *It was an act of God. The will of God. God's own mercy.* Bruce Bennett, cornered on camera by the blond anchor from K-DEV down in Cheyenne, said it was the darnedest thing. Like the hand of God Himself reached down and pulled them out of that pit.

The twenty-three survivors hadn't had time to confer. Once they were past the blockage, they trudged upward to the mouth of Shaft L in silence. They emerged, owls in the late autumn daylight. News vans were already there. Spouses with supervisors who let them off when the news broke or with baby-sitters who could show up on short notice waited within the circle of cameras, along with gawkers down from Gillette, phones ready to catch footage of miners or their bodies coming out of the tunnel.

The survivors had been underground nine hours. There was six solid feet of rubble between them and the surface, too much for God to cut through. God had nothing to do with getting them out. It was Tom Guthridge's oldest boy, Sam, whose forged employment papers said he was eighteen.

The Friday afterward, the Powder Basin mine was closed. All 140 employees were given the full day off with pay. The holding company went over maintenance records and noted how long since an inspector had seen the inside of Shaft L. The best course of action was to keep everyone happy.

The men who hadn't been in Shaft L gravitated toward the Chariot Lounge in Gillette that afternoon. Some said they'd had a bad feeling when they came in Thursday morning. Many claimed they'd heard the shaft go. They lied to feel like part of it. The lies were the way they understood the accident. True stories, made up after the fact.

Among the survivors, twenty spent their free day at home. They clutched their children more tightly than they had since the kids were babies. Dinners tasted better than anything the steak house in Gillette could grill up. That night, with the kids in bed, they made love to their wives the way guys did in the movies, knocking over lamps and tearing at clothes in a rush to get skin pressed to skin. As if they'd found something they'd forgotten losing and only now understood its value. All of them slept deeply and dreamlessly.

Sam Guthridge didn't leave his room the whole day, which wasn't unusual. He was a solitary boy, kind and gentle. His father, Tom, used to say Sam was too soft for this town. Not in anger or disappointment but regret that he couldn't offer Sam better. Tom and Lucy Guthridge had been socking money away for Sam's college. All that came to nothing when Tom got sick. Medical bills ate up the savings faster than the cancer ate through Tom's lungs. Lucy took it as a blessing that her husband hadn't lived long enough to see Sam go into the mines.

Sam didn't talk much to his mother about what happened. "We did what we had to, and we got out," he said. Lucy knew the truth and knew there would be consequences to come. There were times she wished she could take her kids out of the world. Hold them safe and away until the storm passed. But that wasn't the way of things, and as Lucy's mother once said, it rains on the just and the unjust alike.

Sam was a brave boy, but he carried too much. Tom had been the same way. A goofy grin covered the fact that he was holding the world up with

his hands. Sam never knew that side of his father, but he picked it up all the same. You couldn't hide what was in the blood. When Sam didn't come to the dinner table Friday evening, Lucy sent his little sister Paige in with a plate. Sam thanked her quietly and kissed her on the cheek, because among his three little siblings, Paige was his favorite.

Joe Sabine, who'd never kept a woman around more than a week, and Danny Randall, whose wife had run off to Denver with an IRS auditor the previous year, burned Friday on Joe's back porch, both wearing their ratty varsity jackets against the cold of the November evening. They were a long time getting around to what needed talking about. They sucked back cans of Coors and threw the empties over the railing onto the lawn. Danny crushed his third on the armrest of his Adirondack chair, same as he did in high school. Joe followed suit, tossing the resulting disk away like a Frisbee. It was past dusk, and both of them were drunk before Danny mentioned the blue lights that had shot out of the Guthridge kid's eyes. The light cutting through the rock. The thin wisp of smoke, a serpent rising out of the stone. How the boy carved away manhole covers of shale. How the men heaved them aside as the light sheared them from the wall of rubble, edges hot to the touch. Down to the last one, the one that peeled away to show sickly sunlight. And air, air pouring out like beer from a tap, so the men crowded toward the opening, mouths gaping for it. Except Sam, who stepped back and let them, then started in again, widening the hole with his light.

"Wasn't normal," said Joe.

"No shit," Danny said.

"Wasn't any act of God either."

"No," said Danny. "Not God."

Monday, Danny Randall called in sick and drove up to the public library to use the computers. He had to wait in line. No one bothered to chase off the crazies and jerkoffs until the school let out. He was looking for context, a word for what Sam Guthridge was. There was something he remembered hearing on a radio show maybe a year before, driving back from the Chariot after last call. He tried a bunch of searches, but it was "strange abilities am radio late" that hit pay dirt. It was a radio show called *The Monster Report with Jefferson Hargrave*. Tinfoil helmet stuff broad-

cast on one of the Kindred Network stations to which his mother kept her car radio dialed. Danny borrowed a pair of headphones from the desk to listen.

Jefferson Hargrave reminded Danny of the Pentecostal preachers he'd been dragged to see when he was a kid. Sweaty men in starched white shirts railing on about the Lord and His wrath while Danny's mother swooned. Hargrave pounded words like nails into wood. "I've got reports here going back to the fifties," he said. "Government reports. And if you're surprised the government knows about these people, then you have not. Been paying. Attention.

"The thing is? The numbers are increasing. I've charted this, and it's, over the years, it goes . . . swoop, upward and upward. But what do I know? Maybe gamma radiation levels are on the rise, or it's hormones in hamburgers. I mean, the sun causes cancer. In a world where the sun causes cancer, anything is possible.

"This I can tell you. There's no links between these people that I can see. There aren't pockets or hot spots. You know, when some corporation leaks something awful and everyone on Shit River gets ball cancer? It's not like that. Their people, their parents, are normal, like you or me. Which means you could have a kid with gills or x-ray vision right out of nowhere.

"And then what happens to them? Because I can tell you, once one of these people gets spotted? They're not sticking around to talk to the press. They're not registering themselves as weapons. Which, from what I can tell, a lot of them are. They're *weapons*. And once they're found out? They disappear.

"So you're thinking I'm going to say it's the government. That these people are being rounded up and trained at black ops sites to fight the war on terror or come take your guns and your women.

"You know what? That's the best. Case. Scenario. That's what I'm *hoping* for. Because what's more likely? What, it seems to me, is the real nightmare? Is that they are organizing themselves. That they are forming, under our noses, their own army.

"And you have to ask yourself, to what end?"

Danny sat staring at the screen. He clicked the share button and sent

the recording to Joe Sabine. After thinking about it another minute, he sent it to the other survivors. All except Sam Guthridge.

Tuesday after shift, the Chariot seemed like a safe place to talk, although who knew? Maybe the Guthridge kid could hear them from across town or read their thoughts like the sports section of the *News-Record*. That was the damnable thing. You could never know.

Danny bought a round of pitchers. He sprang for the fancy ones from the brewery in Jackson Hole even though it shot his beer budget for the month and left a taste in his mouth like sucking on a penny. Danny let the other men talk. He'd planted the seed and could tell it had found purchase. Alvin McLaughlin brought printouts of blurry photos and typed witness statements. Marc Medina fancied himself an expert on DNA and the effects of gamma radiation thereupon.

"Imagine a string of letters, except only four of them, repeating," he told Scott Lipscombe. "This radiation slices right through them. GTT slice! Like that. Then you've got two loose ends floating around. And they can join up again wherever." He laced his fingers together, then bent them into a tangle. "Genetic mutation," he said.

More rounds got bought. Troy Potter, the weeknight bartender, caught a couple of sideways looks and found things to busy himself with in the back. Talk turned to the subject at hand. What to do about Sam. They all made a point of saying they liked Sam. They acknowledged that they were indebted to him. They owed him their lives for what he did.

"With his *abilities*," Danny added, throwing it out there. "What he did with his abilities."

He let the strangeness of the word do its work on them. Some of the men nodded. Others squirmed.

Lowell Tyler, the oldest rockbreaker at the basin, met Danny's eyes.

"I don't like where you're taking this conversation, Danny," he said. "Even if Tom's boy hadn't saved your ass, which he did. This kind of talk doesn't go anywhere good."

"It's talk," Danny said. He held his hands up innocently. "Situation like this merits discussion, don't you think?" He gave Lowell his best

“we’re all friends here” grin. When it didn’t work on Lowell, he turned it on the rest of the room. People were eager to chime in with agreement.

Lowell had lost a kid in Iraq and trained Tom Guthridge when Tom wasn’t much older than Sam was now. He took Tom’s death harder than anyone. In the weeks after the funeral, Lowell would show up at the Chariot spoiling for it, daring the young bucks to take a swing at him, like he needed physical pain to match what he felt in his gut. No one stepped up and decked the old man even though they would have been doing him a favor.

“I’m having no part of what you’re talking about,” Lowell said. “I’ll tell you, Danny. Put it down. And you two—” He pointed at Alvin McLaughlin and Joe Sabine. “—don’t forget this asshole talked you into breaking into Antelope Valley’s locker room to shit in their helmets when you all were kids.”

“We won that game,” said Joe. His voice was a high whine.

“You two listened to it on the radio in county lockup,” Lowell said. “And Danny got himself off without a hitch. The three of you forget that part.” He held out a ten to Danny. “Here’s for the beers.”

“I got these,” Danny said.

“This is for mine,” said Lowell. Danny took the bill. He looked at it like Lowell had wiped his ass on it. They watched Lowell walk out, then turned to Danny. They weighed what Lowell said. They wondered if they ought to follow him out the door.

Danny slapped the ten down on the bar.

“Looks like Lowell stood us another round,” he said. It got the desired laugh. More important, it put Lowell Tyler’s blessing on them. Lowell said he had no part of it, but Danny had him buying the beers.

“The thing is,” Danny said, “there’s a risk this is the start of something. You can’t know where something like this is going to lead. That’s what we need to find out. The only way to do that is to go have a talk with Sam.”

There would be time later for all the survivors to reconcile their actions and their consciences. Although, as it turned out, not much time. For now they were resolved. And as Danny Randall said, “It might as well be tonight.”

Lucy Guthridge hadn't been to bed since the incident. She drowsed on the sofa or in the armchair after the kids were asleep. When she answered the door in her gray uniform from the diner, she knew this was what had kept her up. A vision of this assemblage, this mob camped out on her lawn. *It's a wonder you all aren't sporting pitchforks*, she thought.

These men had visited Tom in the hospital, where Lucy had held constant vigil. They took up a collection to help Lucy and the four kids, and they kept quiet when Sam, too young to grow a patch of beard if you gave him a month and a miracle, applied for a job in the mine. They'd been at Tom's funeral and come to the reception after at this same house whose lawn they were trampling over.

"It's awful late, Danny," Lucy said. She ignored the rest of them. "Is there something you're needing?"

"We came for Sam," Danny said, avoiding her eyes.

"Sam's earned his rest. Don't you think?"

Danny didn't answer. He stepped past her into the living room. The other men followed, crowding in until Lucy was pressed against the wall. Woken by the noise, the four Guthridge children stood in the hallway that led to their bedrooms. Sam was in a tee shirt and baggy shorts. He looked, Scott Lipscombe thought, like a boy. It was easy to miss that working alongside him, but now, thin limbs jutting out of clothes that were once his father's, Sam didn't look old enough to drive. His younger brother, Jeb, was in flannel pajamas, and the girls, Melody and Paige, were both in nightgowns. The three little ones huddled behind Sam, who held his hands stiff at his sides, fists clenched.

"Come with us, son," Danny said.

"Not your son," said Sam. He didn't move. Paige coughed, shaking off a cold she'd picked up at school. Little Jeb patted her back and rubbed it, then put his hands at his sides, fists tight like his big brother.

The room seethed with drunk energy. Marc Medina giggled nervously, and Alvin McLaughlin shushed him. Scott Lipscombe had his twelve-gauge hanging at the end of his arm, chambers full of rock salt. He felt a fat bead of nervous sweat roll down his temple, and he raised the gun to wipe it with his sleeve. That was when he saw it. He was sure he did. A blue glint in Sam's eye. He remembered the smell of rock burning as the light cut through it. He imagined himself sliced in two and won-

dered what burnt-meat smell his own body would give off. If the smoke would hit his nostrils before he died.

He emptied two chambers of rock salt into Sam Guthridge's gut.

Sam doubled over, the wind knocked out of him. Lucy pitched forward toward Scott, but Alvin McLaughlin grabbed her around the waist and spun her like a drunken dance partner. Paige, the littlest one, screamed. She held the side of her face where she'd been struck. She pulled her hand away to check for blood.

There was none. Where the salt crystals had hit, seven on her cheek and forehead, bright blue light shone through punctured skin.

"Shit," said Danny, "it's all of them."

When the fire burned itself out, the men dispersed. Most went home, where they lay awake next to their wives until dawn. Their minds were full of sounds that would wake them some nights for what was left of their lives.

A small knot, Danny and Joe and a couple of others, took bottles to the mouth of Shaft L. It was blocked off. The fence was a row of sickly teeth. It was the only time the men would talk about what had happened.

"Those lights in her head," said Scott Lipscombe. "They reminded me of a toy I had when I was a kid."

"Lite Brite," Danny said. "I thought that, too." He could picture the lights, the way they traced jagged lines in the dim room as Paige Guthridge's body hitched with sobs. Every time the men cut her, light poured out of the wounds. Danny Randall thought that when she died, the lights would fade like in a theater at the start of a movie. But they went out suddenly, like a candle.

Frankly in Love

David Yoon

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FRANKLY IN LOVE

David Yoon

putnam

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the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously, and any resemblance
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or locales is entirely coincidental.

before we begin

Well, I have two names.

That's what I say when people ask me what my middle name is. I say:

Well, I have two names.

My first name is Frank Li. Mom-n-Dad gave me that name mostly with the character count in mind.

No, really: F+R+A+N+K+L+I contains seven characters, and seven is a lucky number in America.

Frank is my American name, meaning it's my name-name.

My second name is Sung-Min Li, and it's my Korean name, and it follows similar numerological cosmology:

S+U+N+G+M+I+N+L+I contains nine characters, and nine is a lucky number in Korea. Nobody calls me Sung-Min, not even Mom-n-Dad. They just call me Frank.

So I don't have a middle name. Instead, I have two names.

Anyway: I guess having both lucky numbers seven and nine is supposed to make me some kind of bridge between cultures or some shit.

America, this is Korea, Korea, this is America.

Everyone good? Can I go do my thing now?

Good.

the fall season

of the senior year

of the high school period

of early human life

chapter 1

lake girlfriend

Senior year is begun.

Is begun sounds cooler than the more normal *has begun*, because if you say it right, you sound like a lone surviving knight delivering dire news to a weary king on the brink of defeat, his limp hand raking his face with dread. *The final breach is begun, your grace. The downfall of House Li is begun.*

I'm the king in that scenario, by the way, raking my face with dread.

For senior year is begun.

Sometimes I look way back to six months ago, during the halcyon days of junior year. How we pranced in the meadows after taking the PSAT: a practice run of the SAT, which in Playa Mesa, in California, in the United States of America, is widely used to gauge whether an early human is fit for entrance into an institution of higher learning.

But the PSAT?

A mere trial, we juniors sang. *What counts not for shit, your grace!*

How we lazed in the sunlight, sharing jokes about that one reading comprehension passage about the experiment testing whether dogs found it easier to tip a bin (easier) for food or pull a rope (trickier). Based on the passage and results in Figure 4, were the dogs

- A) more likely to solve the rope task than the bin task?
- B) more frustrated by the rope task than the bin task?
- C) more likely to resent their human caregivers for
being presented with such absurd tasks to begin with,
I mean, just give us the food in a damn dog bowl like
normal people?
- Or
- D) more likely to rake a paw over their face with dread?

The answer was D.

For come Score Day, I discovered I got a total of 1400 points out of a possible 1520, the 96th percentile. This earned me plenty of robust, spontaneous high fives from my friends, but to me they sounded like palms—*ptt ptt ptt*—slapping the sealed door of a crypt.

The target was 1500.

When I told Mom-n-Dad, they stared at me with pity and disbelief, like I was a little dead sparrow in the park. And Mom actually said this, for real:

Don't worry, we still love you.

Mom has said the words *I love you* exactly two times in my life. Once for the 1400, and another time when she called after her mother's funeral in Korea when I was ten. Hanna and I didn't go. Dad was at The Store; he didn't go either.

In retrospect, it's weird we didn't all go.

Secretly, in retrospect: I'm glad I didn't go. I met my grandma only once, when I was six. She spoke no English, me no Korean.

So in retro-retrospect, maybe it's not so weird that we didn't all go.

Dad has said the words *I love you* exactly zero times in my life.

Let's go back to that PSAT score.

As a leading indicator, a bellwether, augury, harbinger, and many other words from the now-useless PSAT vocabulary study guide, a score of 1500 would mean I would probably kick the real SAT's ass high enough to gain the attention of The Harvard, which is the Number One Top School in Whole of United States, according to Mom-n-Dad.

A 1400 means I'll probably only ess-ay-tee just high enough to get into the University of California at Berkeley, which in Mom-n-Dad's mind is a sad consolation prize compared with The Harvard. And sometimes, just for a nanosecond, their brainlock actually has me thinking:

Berkeley sucks.

My big sister, Hanna, coined the term *brainlock*, which is like a headlock but for your mind. Hanna lives in Boston near the other Berkeley, the Berklee College of Music.

Berklee is my real dream school. But Mom-n-Dad have

already nixed that notion. *Music? How you making money? How you eating?*

Hanna's two names are Hanna Li (character count: seven) and Ji-Young Li (nine). Dad named Hanna Li after Honali, from a popular 1960s marijuana anthem disguised as a children's song, "Puff (The Magic Dragon)." The song had found its way into high-school English classes in Seoul in the 1970s. Dad has never smoked pot in his life. He had no idea what he was singing.

Hanna is the oldest; Hanna did everything right. Mom-n-Dad told her to study hard, so she got straight As. They told her to go to The Harvard, so she did, and graduated with honors. She moved on to Harvard Law School, and graduated with a leap big enough to catapult her above assistants her same age at Eastern Edge Consulting downtown, which specializes in negotiating ridiculous patents for billion-dollar tech companies. She's even dabbling in venture capital now from her home office high atop Beacon Hill. Weekdays, she wears very expensive pantsuits; weekends, sensible (but still very expensive) dresses. Someone should put her on the cover of a business travel magazine or something.

But then Hanna did the one wrong thing. She fell in love.

Falling in love isn't bad by itself. But when it's with a black boy, it's big enough to cancel out everything she did right her whole life. This boy gave Hanna a ring, which Mom-n-Dad have not seen and might never.

In another family perhaps on another planet, this brown boy would be brought home for summer vacation to meet the

family, and we would all try out his name in the open air: *Miles Lane*.

But we're on this planet, and Mom-n-Dad are Mom-n-Dad, so there will be no Hanna this summer. I miss her. But I understand why she won't come home. Even though it does mean I'll be left high and dry without someone to make fun of the world with.

The last time she came home was a Thanksgiving holiday two years ago. She was at a Gathering. It was the Changs' turn to host. I'm not sure why she did what she did that night. *So I have this boy now*, she said. *And he is The One*.

And she held out her phone with a photo of Miles to Mom-n-Dad and everyone. It was like she cast a Silence spell on the room. No one said shit.

After a long minute, the phone turned itself off.

Mom-n-Dad went to the front door, put on their shoes, and waited with eyes averted for us to join them. We left without a word of explanation—none was needed—and the next morning Hanna vanished onto a flight back to Boston, four days early. A year later, after six or seven Hanna-free Gatherings, Ella Chang dared utter the word *disowned*.

And life went on. Mom-n-Dad no longer talked about Hanna. They acted like she moved to a foreign country with no modern forms of communication. Whenever I brought her up, they would literally—literally—avert their eyes and fall silent until I gave up. After a while, I did.

So did Hanna. Her text message responses fell from every day to every other day, then every week, and so on. This is

how disownment happens. It's not like some final sentence declared during some family tribunal. Disownment is a gradual kind of neglect. Since Mom-n-Dad gave up on Hanna, Hanna decided to give up as well. I get that.

But I never gave up on her. I still haven't.

It's a scary thing to watch someone you love vanish from sight.

I talk a lot about Hanna with Q. Q is what I call my top chap, and I am his.

I'm forever grateful for Q's patience with me, because I can't imagine it makes Q feel all that good to hear how Mom-n-Dad rejected a boy with the same skin color as his.

Q's full name is Q Lee. He Lee and me Li. Like two brothers from Korean and African-American mothers. His parents, Mr. and Ms. Lee, are normal people who seem forever astonished that they gave birth to such a meganerd of a son. Q has a twin sister named Evon who is so smoking hot I can barely look at her. You say Evon Lee like *heavenly*.

Q's Q doesn't stand for anything; it's just Q. Q decided to rename himself a couple months ago on his eighteenth birthday. He was originally born as Will. Will Lee.

Show us your willy, Will Lee, they would say.

Good choice on the name change, Q.

Like most nerds, Q and I spend our time watching obscure movies, playing video games, deconstructing the various absurdities of reality, and so on. We hardly ever talk about girls, for lack of material. Neither of us has dated anyone. The farthest I have ventured out into girl waters is when I accidentally kissed Gina Iforget during a game of spin-the-

ballpoint-pen in junior high. It was supposed to be on the cheek, and both Gina and I missed and touched each other's lips instead. Ooo-ooo-ooo.

The only time and place we even obliquely approach the subject of girl is when we happen to find ourselves sitting on the shore of Lake Girlfriend.

Lake Girlfriend is at Westchester Mall. Westchester Mall is the biggest mall in Orange County. For some reason, they leave all their doors open well past midnight, long after the stores have all shut. The mall becomes a beautifully empty, serenely apocalyptic space that no one in all of Southern California seems to know about.

Only two security guards patrol all seventy gleaming acres of the deserted mall. Their names are Camille and Oscar. They know me and Q and understand that no, we are not dating; we are just two guys with strange ideas of how to pass the time.

Lake Girlfriend is a fountain in Westchester Mall's Crystal Atrium by the Nordstrom anchor store. It is a low polished structure formed from simple modernist angles. It bears a fancy brass plaque that says DO NOT DRINK—RECLAIMED WATER. Above, nameless jazz infuses the cavernous faceted space with echoey arpeggios.

I call it Lake Girlfriend because maybe if I give it enough confessions and offerings, a girl will rise from its shimmering surface and offer me her hand.

Q and I sit tailor-style on a stone ledge the color of chocolate by this fountain. We watch the water bubble up from an octagonal top pool, push through a stone comb, and descend

staggered steps to a pool floor sequined throughout with glimmering coins.

I reach into my army-surplus rucksack and take out my Tascam, a sweet little device no bigger than a TV remote, and record the sound: low, rich syrup layered with pink noise and the occasional pwip of large bubbles. Practically a complete riff unto itself. I click the recorder off and stash it away so that Q and I can begin.

“Ideal traits in a woman,” I say. “You go first.”

Q rests his chin atop his fists. “Speaks at least two other languages.”

“And?” I say.

“Can play the oboe at a professional level,” says Q.

“Q,” I say.

“Ivy League professor by day, ballet renegade by night.”

“I’m assuming this list isn’t based in reality,” I say.

“A guy can dream, right?” says Q.

It’s a little hard to hear him over the white noise of Lake Girlfriend, and I think that’s the thing about this place that makes it easy to talk about things like ideal girls. It’s like talking out loud to ourselves, but in front of each other.

“Your turn,” says Q.

I think. A hundred faces scroll through my mind, all pretty in their own way. A thousand combinations of possibilities. Everyone has loveliness inside if you look carefully. Lots of the world is like this. One time I halved an onion and discovered its rings had squashed one by one to form a perfect heart shape at the core. One time—

“Frank?” says Q. “You gotta move your mouth to speak.”

“Wull,” I say. “I mean.”

Q looks at me, waiting.

“Basically I guess she has to be kind, is most important.”

Q raises his eyebrows. “So no meanies. Got it.”

“And she should make me laugh,” I say.

“Any other vital criteria?” says Q.

I think. Anything else—hobbies, musical tastes, fashion sense—doesn’t seem to matter that much. So I just shake my head no.

Q gives the fountain a shrug. “That’s super romantic, like in the most basic sense.”

“Basically,” I say.

We both stare at the fountain for a moment. Then I mark the end of our visit to Lake Girlfriend with the ritual digging into my front jeans pocket for sacred coins, one for me, one for Q. Q tosses his in with a fart sound. I give mine a squeeze and flip it into the water, ploop. The coins are added to the submerged pile of random wishes: good grades, job promotions, lottery dreams, and, above all, love.

No one comes rising out of the shimmering water.

Q doesn’t know it, but I’ve secretly left out one criterion for my ideal woman. It’s one I’d rather not say aloud, even though it’s the one I worry about the most.

My ideal woman should probably be Korean-American.

It’s not strictly necessary. I could care less. But it would make things easier.

I’ve toed the dating waters only twice before, and each time something has held me back from diving in. A paralysis. I think it comes from not knowing which would be worse:

dating a girl my parents hated or dating a girl my parents loved. Being ostracized or being micromanaged.

Then I consider how Korean-Americans make up only 1 percent of everyone in the Republic of California, out of which 12 percent are girls my age, which would result in a dating pool with only one girl every three square miles. Filter out the ones who are taken, the ones I wouldn't get along with, and—worse—add in the Ideal Woman criteria, and the pool gets even smaller. Lake Girlfriend shrinks down to a thimble.

So I shelve the notion of an ideal girl for now. I realize I've been shelving the idea for years.

"A guy can dream," says Q.

"A guy can dream," I say.

chapter 2

metaphor incoming

Mom-n-Dad's store also has two names, like me and Hanna.

Its official name is Fiesta Hoy Market, which I won't even bother to translate because goddamn, what a stupid name. Its second name is simply The Store. The Store is its name-name.

Mom-n-Dad work at The Store every day, from morning to evening, on weekends, holidays, New Year's Day, 365 days out of every year without a single vacation for as long as me and Hanna have been alive.

Mom-n-Dad inherited The Store from an older Korean couple of that first wave who came over in the sixties. No written contracts or anything. Just an introduction from a good friend, then tea, then dinners, and finally many deep bows, culminating in warm, two-handed handshakes. They wanted to make sure The Store was kept in good hands. Good, Korean hands.

The Store is an hour-long drive from the dystopian

perfection of my suburban home of Playa Mesa. It's in a poor, sun-crumbled part of Southern California largely populated by Mexican- and African-Americans. A world away.

The poor customers give Mom-n-Dad food stamps, which become money, which becomes college tuition for me.

It's the latest version of the American dream.

I hope the next version of the American dream doesn't involve gouging people for food stamps.

I'm at The Store now. I'm leaning against the counter. Its varnish is worn in the middle like a tree ring, showing the history of every transaction that's ever been slid across its surface: candy and beer and diapers and milk and beer and ice cream and beer and beer.

"At the airport," I once explained to Q, "they hand out title deeds by ethnicity. So the Greeks get diners, the Chinese get laundromats, and the Koreans get liquor stores."

"So *that's* how America works," said Q, taking a deeply ironic bite of his burrito.

It's hot in The Store. I'm wearing a Hardfloor tee shirt perforated with moth holes in cool black, to match my cool-black utility shorts. Not all blacks are the same. There is warm black and brown black and purple black. My wristbands are a rainbow of blacks. All garments above the ankles must be black. Shoes can be anything, however. Like my caution-yellow sneakers.

Dad refuses to turn on the air-conditioning, because the only things affected by the heat are the chocolate-based candies, and he's already stashed those in the walk-in cooler.

Meanwhile, I'm sweating. I watch a trio of flies trace an

endless series of right angles in midair with a nonstop zimzim sound. I snap a photo and post it with the caption: *Flies are the only creature named after their main mode of mobility.*

It makes no sense that I'm helping Mom-n-Dad at The Store. My whole life they've never let me have a job.

"Study hard, become doctor maybe," Dad would say.

"Or a famous newscaster," Mom would say.

I still don't get that last one.

Anyway: I'm at The Store only one day a week, on Sundays, and only to work the register—no lifting, sorting, cleaning, tagging, or dealing with vendors. Mom's home resting from her morning shift, leaving me and Dad alone for his turn. I suspect all this is Mom's ploy to get me to bond with Dad in my last year before I head off to college. Spend father-n-son time. Engage in deep conversation.

Dad straps on a weight belt and muscles a hand truck loaded with boxes of malt liquor. He looks a bit like a Hobbit, stocky and strong and thick legged, with a box cutter on his belt instead of a velvet sachet of precious coins. He has all his hair still, even in his late forties. To think, he earned a bachelor's degree in Seoul and wound up here. I wonder how many immigrants there are like him, working a blue-collar job while secretly owning a white-collar degree.

He slams his way out of the dark howling maw of the walk-in cooler.

"You eat," he says.

"Okay, Dad," I say.

"You go taco. Next door. Money, here."

He hands me a twenty.

“Okay, Dad.”

I say *Okay, Dad* a lot to Dad. It doesn’t get much deeper than that for the most part. For the most part, it can’t. Dad’s English isn’t great, and my Korean is almost nonexistent. I grew up on video games and indie films, and Dad grew up on I-don’t-know-what.

I used to ask him about his childhood. Or about basic things, like how he was able to afford a luxury like college. He grew up poor, after all, poorer than poor. Both my parents did, before Korea’s economic supernova in the late eighties. Dad said he would go fishing for river crabs when food ran low. Lots of people in the sticks did.

“Tiny crabby, they all crawling inside my net,” he told me. “All crawling crawling crawling over each other, they stepping on each other face, try to get on top.”

“Okay,” I said.

“That’s Korea,” he said.

When I asked him what that meant, he just closed the conversation with:

“Anyway America better. Better you going college here, learn English. More opportunity.”

That’s his checkmate move for most conversations, even ones that start out innocently enough like, *How come we never kept up with speaking Korean in the house?* or *Why do old Korean dudes worship Chivas Regal?*

So for the most part, he and I have made a habit of leaving things at *Okay, Dad*.

“Okay, Dad,” I say.

I grab my phone and step into the even hotter heat outside. Corrido music is bombarding the empty parking lot from the *carnicería* next door. The music is meant to convey festivity, to entice customers inside. It's not working.

¡Party Today!

Buzz-buzz. It's Q.

*Pip pip, old chap, let's go up to LA. It's free museum night.
Bunch of us are going.*

Deepest regrets, old bean, I say. Got a Gathering.

I shall miss your companionship, fine sir, says Q.

And I yours, my good man.

Q knows what I mean when I say *Gathering*.

I'm talking about a gathering of five families, which sounds like a mafia thing but really is just Mom-n-Dad's friends getting together for a rotating house dinner.

It's an event that's simultaneously ordinary and extraordinary: ordinary in that hey, it's just dinner, but extraordinary in that all five couples met at university in Seoul, became friends, moved to Southern California together to start new lives, and have managed to see each other and their families every month literally for decades.

The day ends. Dad changes shirts, trading his shop owner persona for a more Gathering-appropriate one: a new heather-gray polo that exudes success and prosperity. We lock up, turn out the lights. Then we drive forty minutes to the Kims'.

It's the Kim family's turn to host the Gathering this time, and they've gone all out: a Brazilian barbecue carving station manned by real Brazilians drilling everyone on the word of

the night (*chu•rra•sca•ri•a*), plus a wine-tasting station, plus a seventy-inch television in the great room with brand-new VR headsets for the little kids to play ocean explorer with.

It all screams: *We're doing great in America. How about you?*

Included among these totems of success are the children themselves, especially us older kids. We were all born pretty much at the same time. We're all in the same year in school. We are talked and talked about, like minor celebrities. *So-and-so made academic pentathlon team captain. So-and-so got valedictorian.*

Being a totem is a tiresome role, and so we hide away in the game room or wherever while outside, the littler kids run amok and the adults get drunk and sing twenty-year-old Korean pop songs that none of us understand. In this way we have gradually formed the strangest of friendships:

- We only sit together like this for four hours once a month.
- We never leave the room during this time, except for food.
- We never hang out outside the Gatherings.

The Gatherings are a world unto themselves. Each one is a version of Korea forever trapped in a bubble of amber—the early-nineties Korea that Mom-n-Dad and the rest of their friends brought over to the States years ago after the bubble burst. Meanwhile, the Koreans in Korea have moved on, be-

come more affluent, more savvy. Meanwhile, just outside the Kims' front door, American kids are dance-gaming to K-pop on their big-screens.

But inside the Gathering, time freezes for a few hours. We children are here only because of our parents, after all. Would we normally hang out otherwise? Probably not. But we can't exactly sit around ignoring each other, because that would be boring. So we jibber-jabber and philosophize until it's time to leave. Then we are released back into the reality awaiting us outside the Gathering, where time unfreezes and resumes.

I call us the Limbos.

Every month I dread going to these awkward reunions with the Limbos, to wait out time in between worlds. But every month I'm also reminded that most of the Limbos are actually pretty cool.

Like John Lim (character count: seven), who made his own game that's selling pretty well on the app store.

Or Ella Chang (nine), who shreds at the cello.

Or Andrew Kim (nine), who cowrote a pretty popular book with his YouTube partner.

I used to think the character count in our names was a weird Korean thing.

But it wasn't a weird Korean thing. It was just weird.

I think the type of person who is willing to live in a totally different country is also willing to make up their own weird traditions. Weird makes weird.

Weird also makes for incredibly lucky lives for us kids, and for that I'm always grateful. For real.

At tonight's Gathering the Limbos are holed up in Andrew's room, playing a multiplayer brawler game.

"Hey," I say.

"Hey," they say.

There's John Lim steering his controller in the air, as if that will help anything. There's Andrew Kim, hissing with effort. There's Ella Chang, calmly kicking everyone's ass from behind her horn rims.

"Wanna play?" drawls Ella.

"In a sec."

One of the Limbos is missing. I wander around the house until I find her: Joy Song, sitting alone among big Lego bricks in the pastel room of Andrew Kim's little sister.

Joy Song (character count: seven), second name Yu-Jin Song (nine).

When we were five, six, seven, Joy and I used to sneak the crispy bits off the barbecue table before it was time to eat. We used to stand on our chairs, hold noodles as high as we could, and lower them into each other's open mouths below. We used to put blades of grass down each other's pants, until one day I caught a glimpse of her front and understood that it was now time to be afraid of girls. I've been afraid ever since.

Now Joy Song sits in the corner smelling her upper lip. She glances up at me—*oh, it's just Frank*—and keeps her upper lip curled. It adds an edge of defiance to a face otherwise made up of simple ovalettes. She returns to what she was doing: arranging the Lego bricks in a line.

She's also listening to music through her tiny phone speakers. It sounds like bugs shouting.

“Isn’t that just the best way to listen to music?” I say. “Really respects the artistic intent of the musicians.”

“Hi, Frank,” says Joy, joylessly.

“How you been?”

“Oh, not much,” she says, answering some other question in her head.

I sit at the pile of Lego and feel like I’m ten. “You wanna build something?”

“It’s just that the solid ones are ABS plastic, and the clear pieces are polycarbonate.”

“Oh-kay.” I notice that Joy has changed her hair. On the outside it’s the usual ink-brown shell, but the inside layer has been dyed a lime green that’s visible only in flashes.

She runs her hand through her hair—green flash—and stops, holding her head sideways. Lost in thought. “You can’t 3D-print ABS or polycarbonate. At least I can’t. I don’t have the requisite tech.”

She releases her hair, and the green layer becomes hidden again.

Me and Joy both go to Palomino High. Our classes never intersect. No one outside the Limbos knows we’re Gathering friends. When we pass in the hallways, we just kind of look at each other and move along.

Now that I think about it, why *don’t* we Limbos hang out outside Gatherings?

“Let’s make a tower,” she says.

We fall into an old habit: building a four-by-four tower with the colors ascending in spectral ROYGBIV order. Chk, chk, brick by brick. We do this for a long time, in silence.

The noise of the party phase-shifts, and I look up to see my mom peering in from the doorway. She doesn't have to say anything. All she has to do is look at me, then at Joy, and smile this corny tilted smile.

After Mom vanishes, Joy rolls her eyes hard and groans to the heavens.

"Joy, will you marry me so that House Li and House Song may finally be joined as one?" I say.

"Shut the fuck up," she says, and throws a Lego at me.

She's got a bizarre laugh, kind of like a herd of squirrels.

"God, I'm so screwed," she says finally.

"What's going on?"

"Wu—you know Wu."

Of course I know Wu. Wu is Chinese-American, third gen. Wu is six two, 190 pounds of fighting muscle; a hawk-eyed warrior prince somehow lost in the American high school wilderness. A single glance from him frequently makes girls walk face-first into their lockers.

Wu is 99 percent likely to go to the University of Southern California, which is in Los Angeles. His dad went to USC. His mom went to USC. They have USC license-plate frames on their cars. They still go to the football games.

I once saw Wu and Joy making out between a pair of columns, and the sight of her ovalette jaw moving with his angular one produced that paralyzing mixture of revulsion and fascination you get when you're seeing something you know must surely exist but never thought you'd see with your own eyes.

Q thinks Joy is gorgeous. As a non-Gathering friend, Q is allowed to think that.

Wu's full name is Wu Tang.

Yep.

Joy continues. "Wu's all, *I want to meet your parents*. I'm all, *no*, but he keeps insisting. We had this big fight."

To understand why this is an issue, it's helpful to know that basically every country in Asia has historically hated on every other country in Asia. Koreans hated Chinese, and Chinese hated Koreans, and have forever. Also Chinese hated Japanese hated Koreans hated Thais hated Vietnamese and so on. They all have histories of invading and being invaded by one another. You know how European countries talk shit all the time about each other? Same thing.

"That's stressful," I say with a frown.

Joy and I are up to green bricks now. I hold one up and notice it's the same color as the green hiding in her hair.

"I don't just have boy problems," says Joy. "I have Chinese boy problems."

Koreans hating Chinese hating Koreans hating blablabla.

"Racists," I say.

Joy just nods. She knows I'm talking about her mom-n-dad.

I know this is the point where one of us should say some-damn-thing about Hanna. But what is there to say?

There's plenty to say. But I've said it over and over and over, so many times that I don't have to even actually say it anymore. Now I'm just super tired of saying it.

Our parents are racist. I wish things were different. I miss

Hanna. I wish things were different. Our parents are racist. I miss Hanna.

Chk, chk. We build until we reach the violet bricks. There's a bunch of white and black and brown bricks left over.

"What should we do with these?" I say. "They don't fit into the rainbow spectrum."

This is a ridiculous and obvious metaphor, and Joy smacks my forehead to point it out.

"Metaphor incoming, doosh," she says.

Then we just kind of stare at each other.

"Fuckin' parents, man," I say.